

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Tyndale Open Study Notes

EXO

Exodus 1:1

- *Israel* is the name God had given to Jacob, son of Isaac and grandson of Abraham ([Genesis 32:28](#)).
- Years earlier, Jacob and his family moved to Egypt to escape a severe drought (see [Genesis 46:1-7](#)). His son Joseph's wisdom and leadership guaranteed a steady grain supply (see [Genesis 41:25-49](#); [Genesis 42:1-2](#); [45:5-7](#)).

Exodus 1:1-22

The need for rescue was clearly related to the Israelites' condition. The Egyptians forced the people of Israel to work without mercy ([1:13](#)). It was also related to promises God had made to the patriarchs years earlier.

The Lord had promised Abraham that his descendants would become a great nation, living freely in the land of Canaan. At this time, Abraham's descendants were slaves in Egypt under a pharaoh who wanted to destroy them as a people. God would have to rescue them to fulfill his promises.

Exodus 1:2-4

To learn about the births of Jacob's sons, see [Genesis 29:31-30:24](#) and [35:16-18](#).

Exodus 1:5

- *seventy*: The number 75 in the ancient Greek version and the Dead Sea Scrolls might include the five sons of Ephraim and Manasseh ([Numbers 26:29, 35](#)).
- His jealous brothers sold Joseph, Jacob's eleventh son, into Egyptian slavery ([Genesis 37:18-28](#)). God did good for his people even though Joseph's brothers sinned. When Joseph was in Egypt, God used him to save the chosen people during a severe famine. Without Joseph, the famine could have destroyed them ([Genesis 42:1-2](#); [50:19-20](#)).

Exodus 1:6-7

Jacob's family stayed in Egypt for a long time as part of God's plan. God told Abraham that his descendants would not receive the land of Canaan for 400 years, until the Canaanites' sins were complete ([Genesis 15:13-16](#)).

Even in Egypt, God's promises were working. The descendants of the elderly Abraham and barren Sarah *multiplied ... exceedingly*, just as God had said ([Genesis 15:5](#)). This was because God blessed them ([Psalm 105:24](#)).

Exodus 1:8-10

From about 1650 to 1550 BC, Semitic invaders ruled northern Egypt, where the Israelites lived. The Egyptians called these rulers "shepherd kings" or *Hyksos*. Semitic peoples were ancient groups from the Middle East and North Africa, known for their shared languages (such as Hebrew, Aramaic, or Arabic) and cultural traditions.

Many scholars think these kings supported the Israelites, who might have allied with them. Egypt finally expelled the invaders around 1540 BC. The new rulers of Egypt's 18th Dynasty probably did not trust any remaining Semites, including the Israelites.

Exodus 1:10

The people Pharaoh called *our enemies* were probably the remaining Hyksos (see study note on 1:8–10).

Exodus 1:11

Archaeologists have identified *Pithom and Rameses* with the modern cities of Tell el-Maskhuta and Qantir. Ancient remains show people built these cities during the Late Bronze period (1550–1250 BC), when the Israelites were also present.

Exodus 1:12

Even though the Egyptians worked together to oppress them, the Israelites continued to multiply and spread throughout the land. In this way, God was keeping his promise to give Abraham many descendants ([Genesis 15:5](#)).

Exodus 1:14

The Egyptians could only get stone for building from the far south of the country. In the north, where the Hebrews lived, they used stone only for the most important state and religious buildings.

They built other structures with mortar and bricks made from durable clay. They mixed in seashells or straw to bind it together. After sun-drying in a mold, these materials were surprisingly strong. This was especially true in Egypt, where there was little rain or humidity.

Exodus 1:15

- *Pharaoh* is a title for the Egyptian ruler, not a personal name.
- The origin of the word Hebrew is not clear. When Egyptians and Philistines used this word for the Israelites, it may have been an insult. It likely described a low social class that other people considered unimportant or inferior.
- Whatever the number of Hebrew people, there were clearly more than two midwives for the whole nation (see study note on 12:37). Shiphrah and Puah probably represent the entire group.

The differences between Pharaoh and the midwives were very clear:

- Pharaoh had great political and military power, but the midwives had none.
- Pharaoh had high status, but they had little.
- Pharaoh was a man from the ruling people, and they were enslaved women.
- Pharaoh was rich, and they were poor.
- Pharaoh could have easily forced them to obey, but they did not give in.

Exodus 1:16

If the child is a son, kill him; but if it is a daughter, let her live: This command called for killing only the male children. It would not remove the Hebrews as a source of forced labor.

When the girls grew up, they could marry male slaves from other ethnic groups. In this way, the Hebrews would lose their unity as a people. At the same time, Egypt would still keep a large supply of slaves.

Exodus 1:17

The midwives . . . refused to obey the mighty Egyptian king because they feared God more than they feared Pharaoh ([1:21](#)). Fear of the Lord (reverent awe of him as the almighty Creator and Judge) is the foundation of true knowledge and of wisdom ([Prov 1:7](#); [9:10](#)). The Lord is a friend to those who fear him ([Ps 25:14](#)). The midwives understood that the Lord has more power than any human being.

Exodus 1:19

It might trouble us that the midwives were not candid in giving their main reason for keeping the boy babies alive. Comprehensive honesty is less important to God than absolute faithfulness to him and to his believing community.

Exodus 1:20–21

he gave them families: For most of history, children have had the worthy goal of growing up to raise a family. God graciously granted the universal wish of these women who served him courageously and faithfully.

Exodus 2:1

The man and woman were named Amram and Jochebed ([6:20](#)). • Levi was Jacob's third son by his wife Leah ([Gen 29:34](#)).

Exodus 2:1–25

[Chapter 1](#) established the need for rescue; ch [2](#) describes the preparation of Moses, the rescuer. God used the destruction of the Hebrew boy babies to ensure that the rescuer would be trained (see study note on 2:10) for his task.

Exodus 2:2

a special baby (literally *he was good*): This is probably a reference to his appearance: He was a "perfect" baby.

Exodus 2:3

Papyrus reeds grew plentifully along the many streams into which the Nile River divided in the delta region of northern Egypt. They were light and flexible, well-suited for basket weaving. It is possible that Moses' mother placed the basket in the water exactly where it was most likely to be found by the Egyptian princess.

Exodus 2:5–6

Much like the Ganges River in modern India, the Nile was understood by the Egyptians to be a goddess who had life-giving and healing properties. When Pharaoh's daughter came down to bathe in the river, she was not merely washing but completing her morning devotions. The discovery of the baby floating on the river, in the embrace of the Nile goddess (as she saw it), would be very significant to her. It is also natural for a young woman to feel sorry for a crying baby. The combination of factors may account for her rescuing the child, though she recognized that he was Hebrew (Hebrews and Egyptians practiced circumcision differently).

Exodus 2:7–9

It is evidence of God's grace and sovereignty that Pharaoh's daughter ironically paid Moses' mother to nurse her own baby rather than having him killed according to Pharaoh's command. The narrator seems to imply that the princess realized who the baby's mother was (since she didn't ask any embarrassing questions). If so, the two women chose to understand each other while maintaining a legal fiction. Moses was saved because God was at work, not because anyone was fooled.

Exodus 2:10

God not only saved Moses' life for his future calling, he also arranged for him to receive administrative, military, and leadership training from the oppressors of his people. A pharaoh was expected to sire as many children as was physically possible to prove his power. Male offspring were placed in civil and military positions. It is very likely that the adopted son of a princess would have had such experiences (see [Acts 7:22](#)). • Moses: The princess

gave the child an Egyptian name that is found in the full names of many prominent Egyptians, including the 18th Dynasty pharaohs named *Ahmose* (1550–1525 BC) and *Thutmose* (1504–1390 BC). By naming the child Moses (meaning “to give birth”), the princess was perhaps saying that the Nile, revered as a source of life, had given birth to the baby. The Israelites drew a connection between the name *Moses* and the similar sounding Hebrew term *mashah*, which means “to lift out.”

Exodus 2:11–12

Moses had a privileged upbringing as compared with the toil and hardship of his own people, the Hebrews, but he was willing to identify with them and help them to the point of jeopardizing his own privileges.

Exodus 2:11–15

This section addresses Moses’ first abortive attempt to rescue Israel in his own strength. This incident shows Moses’ courage and decisiveness, but it also shows his tendency to assume the responsibility himself, which would later have tragic effects in his life ([Num 20:1–13](#)). Moses’ concern for his people’s welfare was good; his timing and manner did not accord with God’s plan.

Exodus 2:13

Moses, who had put himself at risk to prevent an Egyptian from beating a Hebrew, must have been especially angered to see a Hebrew beating up a fellow Hebrew.

Exodus 2:14

The arrogant response of the Hebrew man, “Who appointed you to be our prince and judge?” foreshadows how the rest of the Hebrews would respond to Moses in later years—they would not thank him for his efforts on their behalf. If Moses were to succeed, he would have to depend solely on a sense of his divine calling.

Exodus 2:15

Moses fled: By trying to rescue Israel himself rather than through God’s help, Moses made himself a fugitive rather than a leader in Egypt, forestalling God’s purposes for him. Moses’ life was drastically changed as a consequence of his actions (cp. [Num 20:9–13](#); [Deut 3:23–29](#)). • Midian was located on both sides of the Gulf of Aqaba—in the southern Sinai Peninsula and on the western edge of the Arabian Peninsula. A major trade route from southern Arabia passed through this dry and barren area. Its people seem to have been nomadic shepherds and traders (see [Gen 37:28](#)). It was a good place for a fugitive to disappear.

Exodus 2:16

The priest of Midian was named Reuel ([2:18](#)), but later he is called Jethro ([18:1](#)). It was common for a person to have both an official name and a personal name, though in this case it is not clear which is which. Perhaps, like Melchizedek ([Gen 14:18](#)), he represented an indigenous religious class that had not fallen prey to a pagan religion. Reuel’s actions in bringing an offering and sacrifices to God ([Exod 18:12](#)) suggest that this was so.

Exodus 2:16–25

This passage further reveals Moses’ concern for the oppressed and tells of his transition to a new land ([2:18–22](#)). He married, had a child, and lived there for forty years ([Acts 7:30](#)). From a human perspective, there was no way for the Israelites to be rescued through Moses, but it is the divine perspective that matters. The end of this section ([Exod 2:23–25](#)) tells us that God had not forgotten his people; he was only waiting for the time to act ([2:25](#)).

Exodus 2:17

rescued: Now a stranger in a strange land, Moses still could not stand by and allow oppression to continue—he was, by nature, a rescuer. The NLT has captured the correct sense of the Hebrew word, sometimes translated *deliver* or *save*.

Exodus 2:18–20

The father of seven daughters was not about to leave a generous and courageous male—excellent husband material—unaccounted for! We see here the well-known hospitality (see also [Gen 18:1–8](#)) that characterizes the residents of this region to this day.

Exodus 2:24–25

The verbs here speak of a God who is sensitive to his people's needs (heard . . . looked down), who is faithful and reliable (remembered his covenant promise), and who accepts his obligations in a relationship (knew it was time to act).

Exodus 3:1

Sinai is the name usually used for the mountain where God later revealed himself in the covenant (see, e.g., [16:1](#); [19:1–2](#)). Here and in [17:6](#) and [33:6](#) the Hebrew text uses the proper name *Horeb*. Both names presumably refer to the same mountain, so the NLT consistently uses Sinai.

Exodus 3:1–10

These verses indicate a major change will happen in the life of Moses.

Exodus 3:1–4:28

This section presents Moses' call to rescue the Israelites from Egyptian bondage. It is divided into two subsections, [3:1–4:17](#) and [4:18–28](#). The first deals with the call itself, while the second addresses the full implications of accepting that call. Moses was not presented with a mere vocational change; he faced an entire reorientation of his life.

Exodus 3:2

Technically, the angel of the Lord is the Lord's officially authorized envoy, but the expression may be used more broadly of other visible manifestations of the Lord (see [Gen 16:9–13](#); [Judg 13:3](#), [6](#), [21–22](#)). • In the Bible, blazing fire often

represents God's transcendent holiness (see [Exod 19:18](#); [Gen 15:17](#); [1 Kgs 18:38–39](#); [Isa 33:14](#)). • didn't burn up: This may show that God does not wish to consume the vehicle that he sets ablaze for his purposes.

Exodus 3:4

Moses, Moses!: God knows each person by name, and every individual matters to him.

Exodus 3:5

The soil around the bush was holy ground, while the soil on the bottom of Moses' sandals was common. The common cannot touch the holy without being transformed or destroyed (see "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note). At the outset of the Exodus, God was making it plain that he is absolutely "other" than his creation, a reality that cannot be overlooked in a proper divine-human relationship. The word holy occurs only a few times in the Bible prior to [Exod 3:5](#). It now becomes the central descriptor of God in the Old Testament. In other Semitic languages, the same root occurs infrequently. It does not describe a moral quality in these other languages but simply what is "other than" human. The pagan gods, for instance, were "holy" only in the sense of being "other"—they did everything humans do, good and evil, but on a larger scale. In the Bible, by contrast, moral perfection is a central idea of the term *holy*. The one true God is the only being in the universe who truly stands apart from this world and is worthy of being called "holy" in this general sense. The true God is perfectly consistent and moral in his character. Here, at the burning bush, God revealed his otherness. Later at Sinai, he revealed his moral character in his requirements for those who would be his covenant partners (see [Exod 19:6](#); [20:1–23:33](#); see also [Lev 11:45](#); [1 Pet 1:13–16](#)).

Exodus 3:6

This transcendent God had committed himself to Moses' ancestors in a faithful promise maintained for hundreds of years. Moses was in awe of the one, holy, and transcendent God of Abraham. Jesus quoted this verse when he was sparring with the

Sadducees about the concept of resurrection ([Matt 22:32](#); [Mark 12:26](#); [Luke 20:37](#)).

Exodus 3:7

God felt compassion for the ongoing slavery and suffering of Israel.

Exodus 3:8

God would not only rescue them but would take them to their own . . . land that he had promised to Abraham ([Gen 13:14-18](#)). • flowing with milk and honey: The land was agriculturally rich, with pasturage for cattle and crops with blooms from which bees could make honey. • Canaanites . . . Jebusites: The list of peoples who lived in Canaan indicates the importance of this strip of land between the Mediterranean Sea and the Arabian Desert. As a vital crossroads for trade and communication between Egypt and the rest of the ancient Near East, it was a hotly contested prize. That Israel could end up in sole possession of it seemed an impossibility.

Exodus 3:10

God would act compassionately to save his suffering people, but it would be through a human agency. Often God is known among us because of the way his people carry out his will.

Exodus 3:11-12

Moses first protested that he was unworthy of such a great task, but God responded that this was not the issue. Human worthiness is of no significance if God's presence is with that person.

Exodus 3:11-4:17

Moses, in his response to God, presented four reasons why he was not the one to fulfill God's call. Although each reason supposedly relates to Moses and his ability, God's answers show that they were really questions about God.

Exodus 3:12

In the Bible, a sign often occurred after a person or a nation had already had to decide whether to act in faith or not (see [Isa 7:14](#)). A sign cannot create faith where there is none (see [Matt 12:39](#); [16:4](#)). Rather, it encourages the one who has exercised the faith he or she already has.

Exodus 3:13-22

The second protest Moses made was about his lack of knowledge. He said that he did not know God's name.

This could mean that God's personal name had not yet been made known to him (see study notes on 6:2-3). It could also mean something else. In the ancient Near East, people often believed that knowing a god's secret name gave them power. Moses may have wondered if he needed such a secret formula (special words believed to control spiritual power).

God's answer is direct, but it sounds almost like a riddle at first. However, most of his answer does not focus on a secret name. Instead, God speaks about his faithfulness in the past and his plans for the future. He shows that he knows what will happen and that he controls history.

There is nothing magical about the name "the LORD" (Hebrew *Yahweh*). The issue is not secret knowledge or magic power. The issue is who God is.

The name is important because of the character and nature of the one who bears it. God is faithful, powerful, and Lord over all of history.

Exodus 3:14

I Am Who I Am: This name speaks of a God who is self-sufficient, self-existent, all encompassing, and without limitations, the one being in the universe who is not dependent on something else for his existence.

Exodus 3:15

Yahweh is probably a form of the Hebrew verb "to be," so it could mean "he causes to be," or "he who is," or "I am." Later Jews were not permitted to

speak God's name aloud, so the Hebrew text supplies the vowels from the word 'adonay (which means "lord" or "master") whenever God's proper name, YHWH, appears. In oral reading, the Hebrew reader would pronounce 'adonay, even though the written text is YHWH. We do not know the pronunciation of the divine name. The widely used *Yahweh* is an informed guess. The English word "Jehovah" is an artificial term made by combining the vowels of 'adonay with the consonants Y-H-W-H. In the NLT, this name is usually translated "Lord" (with small capitals), but it is transliterated "Yahweh" in the few instances, like this verse, where a point is made about the name itself. Also in [6:2-3](#); [15:3](#); [33:19](#); [34:5-6](#).

Exodus 3:16–17

Moses was to tell the people of Israel that the God who now spoke to them was the same God their ancestors knew and worshiped, and that he would lead them into a fruitful land wrested from the hands of many others. Moses' message was not a magical formula, but the word of a God who, standing outside of history, can yet enter and direct it. • flowing with milk and honey: See study note on 3:8.

Exodus 3:18

Hebrews: See study note on 1:15. • a three-day journey . . . to offer sacrifices: If we think of the primary purpose of the Exodus as rescuing the Israelites from bondage, this seems like a disingenuous request. But God's primary purpose was to create a people for himself, and he was taking them into the wilderness to teach them to worship him.

Exodus 3:19

I know: See "Hardened Hearts" Theme Note.

Exodus 3:20–21

God's power would be obvious, and the Egyptians would not only allow the Hebrews to leave, they would pay them to do so.

Exodus 4:1–9

Moses' third protest was that he lacked power. God answered in a very convincing demonstration of divine power by instantaneous creation of a snake and of a severe skin disease.

Exodus 4:3

Across the ancient Near East, the snake was a symbol of both death and healing. The person who demonstrated power in these areas was powerful indeed.

Exodus 4:6

severe skin disease: The Hebrew word underlying this phrase has traditionally been translated "leprosy." However, the symptoms of this condition as described in the Bible are not those of the disease we know as leprosy (Hansen's disease). The biblical term seems to describe several kinds of highly contagious inflammations and skin lesions.

Exodus 4:9

As with the previous two signs, the fact that the water from the Nile will turn to blood also demonstrated God's power over life and death.

Exodus 4:10–17

Moses' fourth and final protest was that he could not speak effectively. Moses was apparently grasping at straws in trying to escape this dangerous and unpleasant assignment, and God was becoming angry at Moses' refusal to grasp the truth. The outcome did not depend on Moses' ability, but upon his willingness to let God's power operate through him.

Exodus 4:11

God created the organs of speech and has ordained every person's particular abilities in this area. He is able to use what he has made and ordained.

Exodus 4:13

After raising several objections, Moses had no more arguments. So he simply asked the Lord to excuse him from the task.

Exodus 4:14–17

God did not allow Moses to avoid his responsibility. However, he responded to the concern of Moses by appointing his brother Aaron to speak for him ([14:16](#)). Aaron would serve as the mouthpiece of Moses before Pharaoh and the people.

As the story continues, the text records fewer occasions when Aaron speaks on behalf of Moses. Moses increasingly speaks directly.

This suggests that the speaking difficulty of Moses may not have been as severe as he feared. It may also be that his confidence and ability grew with experience.

Exodus 4:18

Moses was now 80 years old (see [7:7](#)). Even so, he was still formally under the authority of his father-in-law.

Exodus 4:20

he took the staff of God: Whatever he may have said to Jethro, Moses was going to Egypt in obedience to God and in the expectation of being used by God (see [4:17](#)).

Exodus 4:21–23

These verses summarize the events of the next several chapters, beginning with the request to let the people go so that they could worship God ([5:3](#)) and concluding with the final plague, the death of the firstborn ([11:4–6](#)). God was preparing the rescuer for the difficult task ahead (see [11:9](#)).

Exodus 4:24–26

This incident is shrouded in mystery. That Zipporah responded immediately and circumcised her son suggests that she and Moses had discussed

the possibility of doing so previously and had decided it was not necessary. Why would having an uncircumcised son lead to God's intent to kill the rescuer he had carefully prepared and called? Perhaps if Moses had arrived in Egypt claiming to represent the God of the Israelites' ancestors and yet had not done the one thing God had commanded of his followers to this point ([Gen 17:10](#)), then the people would have been less inclined to follow God in a radically exclusive way.

Exodus 4:25

a bridegroom of blood: The context suggests that this statement was part of a circumcision ceremony.

Circumcision was the cutting of the foreskin of a male child. It may reflect an older custom among some Semitic peoples (ancient groups from the Middle East who spoke related languages).

Among some groups, including certain African communities today, circumcision is performed at puberty rather than in infancy. If that were the case here, the phrase may connect circumcision with marriage or adulthood.

Exodus 4:27

Aaron's coming to meet Moses is the first recorded confirmation of God's promises (see [4:14](#)). • mountain of God: A reference to Mount Sinai.

Exodus 4:29–7.7

In this section, the Lord offered to rescue the Israelites. The people initially gave a favorable response but ultimately faced a crisis of faith.

Exodus 4:31

the people of Israel were convinced: The initial response to the good news was one of faith and worship. Contrast the response of panic in [14:10–12](#), when they saw Pharaoh chasing them.

Exodus 5:1

so that they may hold a feast: See study note on 3:18.

Exodus 5:1-14

Pharaoh not only rejected Moses' request to release the Hebrew slaves, he also retaliated by making their work harder. The arrival of the rescuer had actually made the situation worse.

Exodus 5:2

Pharaoh immediately moved to the heart of the issue. What god could possibly be superior to Pharaoh? What god could compel him to do what he did not want to do? This is a central issue for the whole human race. Is there someone or something greater than my self-interest?

Exodus 5:3

he will kill us: God had not said this. Perhaps Moses and Aaron were trying to strengthen their case by saying that they had to obey God or die.

Exodus 5:4-5

It seems that the people expected the freedom God had promised. Because of this, they stopped their work.

Exodus 5:6-14

Pharaoh increased the workload to punish their disobedience. He thought they had too much free time (5:8). He could not imagine a god revealing himself outside the royal worship system. He believed they invented their unusual religious ideas instead of working (see also 5:17).

Exodus 5:7

Straw is a binder to help clay and mud bricks retain their form while drying in the sun.

Exodus 5:22

The phrase brought all this trouble could be translated even more strongly as *done all this evil*. Is God really good or not? Instead of rescuing the people out of their evil circumstances as he had promised, it seems that God had only made the situation worse. Is he faithful or not? Is he powerful or not? (cp. [Ps 105:25-27](#)).

Exodus 5:22-23

This was the crisis point. After the initial burst of enthusiasm ([4:29-31](#)), the offer of rescue produced nothing but skepticism, hostility, and worse oppression than before. Moses, the rescuer, was himself reduced to doubt.

Exodus 6:1

Now you will see: Far from being daunted by the questions being raised about his integrity, his ability, and his very character, God looked forward to the clash of worldviews that lay ahead. Pharaoh, thinking himself divine, would just be a pawn in the hand of the one true God.

Exodus 6:1-13

God renewed his promises. The offer of rescue brought the true question to the fore, the question articulated by Pharaoh: Who is the Lord ([5:2](#))? As much as the Israelites needed rescue from bondage, their greater need was to know the Lord. The climax of God's renewed promises was "you will know that I am the Lord your God" ([6:7](#)).

Exodus 6:2-3

I am Yahweh . . . El-Shaddai: Here the NLT transliterates the divine names *Yahweh* and *El-Shaddai* because God was emphasizing that he was now using a different name than the name by which he was known to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. To assist the English reader, the translators have also supplied the English terms usually used for these Hebrew terms: "the Lord" and "God Almighty." • I did not reveal my name, Yahweh, to them: The name Yahweh in fact appears frequently in Genesis (translated "the Lord"). Two solutions are possible:

(1) The name Yahweh was not known to the patriarchs, but Moses, the author of Genesis, was inspired to insert that name in those places in Genesis where God's grace and his nature as covenant-keeper were apparent. While the patriarchs might have known the name Yahweh, it is possible that they had never seen God's nature displayed as it was in the Exodus and the Sinai covenant. In Hebrew, a person's name has a broader significance than it does in English. People's names were intended to reflect their character and nature, not just serve as a label (see, e.g., [Pss 8:1, 9; 148:13](#)). Here reveal is a Hebrew word often translated "to know," which implies intimate knowledge and experience. In this case, the patriarchs knew God's name, but they did not know and experience his nature fully as he revealed himself in the Exodus.

Exodus 6:2–8

Once again, God forcefully linked his promises to the patriarchs (Abraham's family) with what he was about to do. God's work in history shows his faithfulness. He has made promises, and he will keep them. God also wished to reveal more of himself than he had been able to do with the patriarchs. This generation would know more of God and his intentions than Abraham had, particularly regarding the implications of the covenant ([6:4–5](#)). Why does God redeem ([6:6](#))? Why did he reveal himself to Abraham in the first place? God wanted the Israelites to be his own people, and he wanted to be their God ([6:7](#)). God's goal is for humanity to be in a lovingly submissive covenant relationship with him, where we can be what he made us to be.

Exodus 6:7

Then you will know that I am the Lord: The Hebrew word translated *know* is always based on experience and relationship. The same word is used to describe human sexual relations. To *know* God as Yahweh is not just to know abstract facts about him, but to be in a relationship with him in which we are always learning who he is and what he wants us to do. This is the only true rescue from the human predicament of sin described in [Gen 3–11](#). The importance of "knowing the Lord" in the book of Exodus is seen in its recurrence, especially

in [Exod 5–18](#) ([5:2](#); [7:5](#), [17](#); [8:10](#), [22](#); [9:29](#); [10:2](#); [11:7](#); [14:4](#), [18](#); [16:6](#), [12](#); [18:11](#)).

Exodus 6:9

The crisis deepened as the people refused to listen to the reaffirmation of the promises. They had not anticipated that their initial faith would produce greater problems for them.

Exodus 6:10–13

The crisis hit bottom. Even Moses was back to the situation on Sinai, where he had first responded to God's call with protests of inadequacy ([3:1–4:13](#)). But God renewed his orders.

Exodus 6:14–16

The genealogy works its way through Jacob's first and second sons to the third, Levi, the ancestor of Moses and Aaron. Having reached Levi, it dispenses with the other nine sons.

Exodus 6:14–30

This genealogical interlude places Moses and Aaron among the families of Israel. That it is an interlude is clear because [6:30](#) is a repetition of [6:12](#). There is a recurring emphasis in Exodus on Yahweh as the God of the ancestors, both explicitly (from [3:6](#) on) and implicitly (from [1:1](#) on). What was about to happen was not an unrelated action by some new god who was devaluing impotent older gods (a typical theme in ancient pagan literature). Unlike pagan gods, whose only purpose is personal power, and who are in constant conflict among themselves, the true God has a single, overarching purpose: He wants his creation to find its fulfillment in proper relation to him. Although he enacts that purpose in ever-expanding displays of creativity, the new activities are always consistent with what he has already revealed of himself. Moses and Aaron did not suddenly appear out of the unknown, but were an integral part of that same people to whom God first revealed himself and through whom he was about to give an even grander revelation. The genealogies of Jesus have a similar purpose ([Matt 1:1–16](#); [Luke 3:23–38](#)).

Exodus 6:16–20

This genealogy of Levi's descendants focuses on Aaron and Moses; four generations are given in the genealogy from Levi to Aaron and Moses (cp. [Gen 15:16](#)). Since the people of Israel had lived in Egypt for 430 years (see [Exod 12:40–41](#); [Gen 15:13](#)), this genealogy skips numerous generations. In [Gen 46:11](#), Gershon, Kohath, and Merari are listed as the actual sons of Levi who moved down to Egypt with their father and the rest of Jacob's family. Amram's wife, Jochebed, gave birth to his sons ([Exod 6:20](#)). This is very concrete language, so there is no reason to believe that there were unnamed generations between Amram and Aaron and Moses. This suggests that the unnamed generations were between Kohath (son of Levi) and Amram (father of Aaron and Moses).

Exodus 6:18

The descendants (literally *sons*) of Kohath included Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel: The Hebrew word for "sons" can also mean "descendants," which accommodates the possibility of unnamed generations.

Exodus 6:20–25

The descendants of Kohath's sons now become the focus of the genealogy. The families of Aaron son of Amram and Korah son of Izhar are given a more detailed listing ([6:23–24](#)), followed by one of Aaron's sons, Eleazar ([6:25](#)). The focus is clearly on Aaron's line through Eleazar, who received the high priesthood. The fact that Aaron and Korah were cousins makes it easier to see why Aaron's elevation to high priesthood was so galling to Korah (see [Num 16:1–3](#)); family rivalry is nothing new. The later rebellion might explain why Korah and his sons are given particular mention in this genealogy.

Exodus 7:1–7

In this final scene in the offer of rescue, the Lord once again answered Moses' fears of not being able to speak eloquently. He would allow Moses to speak through Aaron (see [4:16](#)), but Pharaoh will

refuse to listen regardless. God's power, not Moses' eloquence, was the important factor. Moses and Aaron then took the step of faith and did what God had commanded. The first crisis (see study note on [5:22–23](#)) had passed.

Exodus 7:3

The Lord would use miraculous signs and wonders to convince Pharaoh, just as he had promised to use signs to convince the Israelites that they should follow Moses ([3:12](#); [4:5](#), [8](#), [9](#)).

Exodus 7:5

my powerful hand: A further revelation of God would take place in the exodus of the Israelites from Egypt, revealing God's incomparable power.

Exodus 7:7

Although eighty seems old to us, the typical age of Moses and Aaron's ancestors at death had been between 130 and 140 years (see [6:16](#), [18](#), [20](#)).

Exodus 7:8–11.10

In the plagues, God showed that all the Egyptians' so-called gods, supposed to be sources of life, were really sources of death apart from the life-giving power of the Lord (see [12:12](#); [18:11](#)).

Exodus 7:8–12.30

This section divides the events of rescue into two parts: the plagues ([7:8–11:10](#)) and the Passover ([12:1–30](#)). God demonstrated that he is the Lord of life and death and nothing has any power against him (see [Isa 43:13](#)). The God of the patriarchs is also the God of the universe.

Exodus 7:9

Serpent (Hebrew *tannin*) is a different word than the word translated "snake" in [4:3](#). *Tannin* often refers to a sea monster. Egypt is often portrayed as an ultimately impotent sea monster ([Isa 30:7](#); [Ezek](#)

[29:3](#)). The image of a cobra's head was on the pharaoh's headdress.

Exodus 7:11

these Egyptian magicians did the same thing (see also [7:22](#); [8:7](#)): While demonic power might have been involved, it is also possible that some sleight of hand was being practiced. When they could not reproduce the plague of gnats, they declared that it was “the finger of God” ([8:19](#)), indicating that their own actions were not a manifestation of divine power. While the Egyptian magicians are not identified by name, tradition gives their names as Jannes and Jambres (see [2 Tim 3:8](#)).

Exodus 7:14

See Theme Note for “Hardened Hearts.”

Exodus 7:14–25

The first plague was the plague on the Nile, when the whole river turned to blood ([7:20](#)). The Egyptians correctly understood that without the Nile there would be no life in Egypt. They worshiped the Nile as the Mother of Egypt, but God showed that life is his to give or withhold.

Exodus 7:22

The Egyptian priests did not do anything as extensive as Moses and Aaron had done, but Pharaoh did not want to believe, so it took only the smallest thing to justify his unbelief.

Exodus 8:1–15

The second plague was the plague of frogs ([8:2](#)). The Egyptians gave special reverence to amphibians because of their ability to live in two different worlds; Egyptians were deeply concerned with survival in the next world, after death. God showed that frogs have no special hold on life. This plague is sometimes said to have been a natural result of whatever happened to make the Nile River uninhabitable. However, the extent of the plague was more than a natural result.

Exodus 8:7–8

The magicians were able to duplicate the plague in some sense, but Pharaoh did not ask them to rid the land of the frogs. Instead, he begged Moses to ask God to take them away. He already knew where the real power was.

Exodus 8:9

In this instance, the evidence of God's power was not in the event per se but in the timing. God could keep the frogs alive or he could end their lives. Pharaoh needed only to say when.

Exodus 8:10

you will know that there is no one like the Lord our God: Once more the issue is highlighted (see [7:17](#)). These events were not primarily about rescue, but about the nature of reality. Who was rescuing these people—one of the gods, or the one true God, the Lord?

Exodus 8:13

Moses requested: Moses predicted that the plague would stop the next day. God also predicted that Pharaoh would refuse to listen (see [8:15](#)).

These statements show an important truth. The ability to predict the future is central to God's lordship (his rule and authority). God does not guess about what will happen. He knows what will happen.

God sees the future clearly. He also directs events according to his will. Because he knows and controls the future, he is truly the Lord.

Exodus 8:16–19

The third plague was the plague of gnats. The word translated “gnats” is very general. Technical Old Testament dictionaries often translate it as “vermin.” The English term “bugs” would come close. The whole land was infested with insects of one sort or another.

Exodus 8:19

This is the finger of God: See study note on 7:11.

Exodus 8:20-32

The fourth plague was the plague of flies. The Egyptians worshiped insects such as flies that seemed to be able to turn death into life, as their young seemed to emerge from decaying matter. If the Egyptians thought that insects had the secret of life, God would let them have all the insects they wanted. Some say that this infestation was the natural result of all the dead frogs, but there were no flies in Goshen (8:22), the northeastern delta area where the Hebrews lived. God's miraculous power was clearly seen in his ability to infest one area while sparing another at will.

Exodus 8:25

Pharaoh attempted to bargain with God. He wanted to obey partially while still retaining control. James says of such people, "Their loyalty is divided between God and the world" (Jas 1:8), and such a person cannot receive anything from the Lord.

Exodus 8:26-27

- Moses explained why Pharaoh's request could not work. He said it would offend the Egyptians. The Egyptians looked down on the Hebrews and other Semitic peoples. They considered them uncultured and unclean (see [Genesis 43:32](#)).
- The Hebrews were leaving Egypt in order to worship the Lord (see, for example, [Exodus 5:1](#); [7:16](#); [8:1](#), [20](#)). God's purpose in the exodus was not only freedom from slavery. He wanted to bring his people into a right relationship with him.

Exodus 8:29-30

I will pray: Moses was learning the role of intercessor that would be so much a part of his life

in future years (see, e.g., [32:11-13](#), [30-32](#); [Num 14:13-19](#)). It must have been increasingly tempting to let the Egyptians continue to experience the results of their king's stubbornness, but Moses was willing to plead with God not to leave them in a permanent state of grief and distress.

Exodus 9:1-7

The fifth plague was against the livestock. As with the withholding of flies from the area where the Hebrews lived ([8:22-23](#)), the distinction between the livestock of the Israelites and that of the Egyptians ([9:4](#)) shows that a natural explanation of this event is insufficient, even if the previous plagues contributed. The Egyptians, like many in the ancient Near East, worshiped the ram, the goat, and the bull as representing power and fertility. These animals had no power before the Lord, in whom true power resides.

Exodus 9:3

Your livestock refers specifically to field animals. Other animals would have boils inflicted upon them in the next plague. • The term all (also in [9:6](#)) is not absolute; it does not mean that every single livestock animal was killed. There were still some left to protect from the hail of the seventh plague ([9:20](#)).

Exodus 9:5-6

Prediction again played an important role. These events were being directed by the One who is sovereign over all that happens.

Exodus 9:8-12

The sixth plague brought festering boils on humans and animals. At this point the magicians, far from being able to duplicate the sign, were unable to spare themselves from it. Their defeat was complete.

Exodus 9:12

Plagues five and six apparently dissipated on their own, since there was no plea by Pharaoh to bring them to an end.

Exodus 9:13-33

The seventh plague was a hailstorm ([9:18](#)). It rains in Egypt only a few days each year, and hail and thunderstorms are largely unknown, so this storm would have been terrifying. That may be why there is more theological reflection associated with it. The devastating effect of the plague was to destroy the flax and barley crops ([9:31](#)).

Exodus 9:14-17

God explained the purpose of the plagues to Pharaoh: They were revelatory, designed to demonstrate (especially to Pharaoh) that there is no one like me in all the earth ([9:14](#); see also [Isa 46:9](#); [Jer 10:6-7](#)). God had not destroyed Pharaoh and Egypt in a single blow, as he could have done. Rather he had spared them ([Exod 9:16](#)), giving them an opportunity to submit to his power. But Pharaoh refused to humble himself and stop lording it over the Lord's people ([9:17](#)).

Exodus 9:16

In [Rom 9:17](#), Paul quotes from the Greek version of this verse as he describes the sovereignty of God.

Exodus 9:20-21

Some of Pharaoh's officials were beginning to make appropriate deductions from their experiences thus far and to take precautions, while others imitated their master's refusal to submit. Pride often dominates reason.

Exodus 9:26

The hail was not a natural event, either in extent or in selectivity (see study note on 9:1-7).

Exodus 9:27

Pharaoh was driven to a logical conclusion. In the face of such clear evidence to the contrary, pride was not merely a failure, it was a sin.

Exodus 9:29

There is no one like the Lord in all the earth ([9:14](#)), and all the earth belongs to the Lord. This was the inescapable message of the plagues, though the Egyptians had difficulty accepting it.

Exodus 10:1-20

The eighth plague was the plague of locusts ([10:4](#)). Evidently enough time had elapsed between this plague and the previous one that the wheat and emmer wheat had sprouted (see [9:32](#)). The Egyptian god Osiris was especially revered as the god who descended into the underworld and brought plant life back in the spring. This second, climactic attack on the plant life demonstrated that even Osiris was helpless before the Lord. There is no eternal life in sprouting plants.

Exodus 10:2

The plagues were sent so that Israel will know that I am the Lord (similarly, with respect to Egypt, see [9:14-16](#)).

Exodus 10:4

These locusts were not the insects called locusts in North America, but a form of migratory grasshopper. Swarming out of desert regions, they could devastate large areas of land, devouring all the plant life before them.

Exodus 10:7-11

The officials, with no royal prestige on the line, were willing to learn the lessons of God's sovereignty and let the men go. Pharaoh again resisted, in an effort to save face somehow. He would let them go only if they left their families behind and were thus bound to return, but Moses had never said they would return. While the

purpose for going into the wilderness was to worship God, it was unthinkable that oppressed slaves would willingly return to their oppressors once they were free, and Pharaoh knew it.

Exodus 10:13

an east wind: The grasshopper swarms came from the Arabian Desert, across the Red Sea to the east.

Exodus 10:13–15

The miraculous nature of the locust plague was indicated by its timing (when Moses raised his staff) and by its extent and intensity (from one end of the country to the other, and there has never been another one like it).

Exodus 10:17

Forgive my sin: Pharaoh's recognition grew deeper; he admitted that his pride and refusal to keep his word were sins, and he recognized that sin cannot be ignored but must be forgiven. Unfortunately, his correct theological understanding did not in itself change his heart.

Exodus 10:21–29

The ninth plague was the plague of darkness ([10:21](#)). The chief god of Egypt through the centuries, who appeared under several different names, was the sun. At this time he was known as Amon-Re. He was supreme over all the other gods and was considered to be the ultimate source of life. The Lord showed that the sun's light is completely under his control; he could shut it off from Egypt proper, while leaving it to shine in Goshen in the northeast part of the country ([10:23](#); see study note on 9:1–7).

Exodus 10:24

leave your flocks and herds: Pharaoh again attempted to save some scrap of his prestige and authority from the debacle.

Exodus 10:25–26

Moses was unrelenting. He knew that the Israelites, far from leaving any of their possessions behind, would be receiving gifts from the Egyptians, who would hurry them away ([3:21–22](#)). He also kept the focus on the worship of God. This continual refrain about the purpose for leaving Egypt (see study note on 8:26–27) reflects the key purpose of their exodus, to become the people of God.

Exodus 10:27–29

Pharaoh seemed to realize that he had reached a point of no return. If he would not submit—the only action appropriate to what he had learned from the plagues—then he must kill the messenger. This reasoning is similar to that of the religious leaders later during the life of Christ. They refused to draw the appropriate conclusions from Jesus' life and ministry, so they decided to kill him (see [John 11:45–53](#)).

Exodus 11:1–9

The final plague was the death of the firstborn sons. The Egyptians worshiped life. They gave so much attention to preparations for life after death because they wanted to ensure that it would be at least as good as their lives in Egypt. Death itself is in God's hand. There is no underworld god who can ultimately defeat the God of life. Both life and death belong to the Lord.

Exodus 11:3

Pharaoh refused to recognize the truth, but the Lord ensured that the rest of Egypt would recognize it.

Exodus 11:5

In much of the world, the issue of survival is addressed through children, and it is through the firstborn sons that the family line is carried on. If we have a child, there is a sense of satisfaction that even when we are dead, we will live on through our children. In the death of the Egyptian firstborn, God was showing that humans can do nothing by

themselves to guarantee survival. Life is a gift, and that gift is in the hand of the one Lord, the “I Am.”

Exodus 11:7

As stated explicitly in the fourth, fifth, seventh, and ninth plagues ([8:23](#); [9:6](#), [26](#); [10:23](#)), the Lord distinguished between his people and the Egyptians. These events clearly resulted from the express activity of God and were not just a chance collection of natural tragedies.

Exodus 11:8

Pharaoh had lost control. Moses was no longer asking; he was now in a position to dictate the terms of the Israelites' departure from the country.

Exodus 12:1–30

The Lord gave Moses instructions for the Passover meal and the Festival of Unleavened Bread ([12:14–20](#)), and Moses and the people observed the first Passover ([12:21–30](#)).

Exodus 12:2

This month was the month Abib ([13:4](#); [23:15](#); [34:18](#); [Deut 16:1](#); later called by the Babylonian name, Nisan, [Neh 2:1](#); [Esth 3:7](#)), which falls within the months of March and April. Many cultures held festivals about this time of the year, celebrating the renewal of plant life. Israel's festival celebrated the historic event in which God defeated death and rescued his people from bondage in Egypt.

Exodus 12:5

with no defects: We must give God our best, just as he gave us his best: “the sinless, spotless Lamb of God” ([1 Pet 1:19](#)).

Exodus 12:6

the whole assembly of the community: Both the benefits and the responsibility of a relationship with God are realized in community.

Exodus 12:7

blood: God could not simply exempt his people from this plague as he had preserved them from the other plagues. Death reigns in the world because of sin, and in light of God's justice, sin cannot be ignored; it must be either punished or atoned for. Since the blood represents life ([Lev 17:11](#)), it alone is acceptable for the forgiveness of sins ([Heb 9:22](#)). As [Deut 6:9](#) suggests, doorframes represent the totality of life as the place of going in and coming out.

Exodus 12:10

Since this was not a regular meal, none of the meat was to be saved for another day.

Exodus 12:11

Be fully dressed: The Israelites were to be ready to depart at a moment's notice.

Exodus 12:12

The plagues were primarily the Lord's judgment against all the gods of Egypt (see also [Num 33:4](#)).

Exodus 12:14

The Jewish people still commemorate Passover, since it was instituted as a law for all time.

Exodus 12:15

without yeast: Israel needed unleavened bread for traveling (see [12:34](#), [39](#)), which the festival commemorated. Later, yeast was seen as an image of sin, probably because it is an agent of fermentation (“Beware of the yeast of the Pharisees,” [Matt 16:6](#)). • cut off from the community: This means either death or expulsion from the community.

Exodus 12:22

Hyssop is a small bush with stiff, compact branches that can serve as a brush (see also [Ps 51:7](#) and study note).

Exodus 12:25

The land the Lord has promised to give you refers to the land of Canaan, which God had promised to Abraham ([Gen 12:7](#); [13:14-17](#)).

Exodus 12:26-27

In the future, the Passover celebration would be a memorial reminding future generations of Israelites of God's grace in providing them a way of escape from death. For more than 3,000 years the Jewish people have celebrated this great formative event in their history.

Exodus 12:28-30

The predicted plague was fulfilled. Just as death exempts no one, so no one in Egypt, from Pharaoh to the lowest prisoner, escaped the effects of Pharaoh's pride.

Exodus 12:31-33

The same Pharaoh who had said that Moses would never again see his face and live (see [10:28](#)) now asked for Moses to come and see him. Just as God had predicted, Pharaoh then ordered the Israelites to leave his land. He implicitly recognized the Lord's power as he asked Moses to bless him. He never formally admitted that the Lord is God and that he, Pharaoh, was not.

Exodus 12:31-14:31

The Lord delivered on his promises and rescued Israel, bringing them out of Egypt.

Exodus 12:35

asked the Egyptians: See [3:22](#); [11:2](#).

Exodus 12:37

Scholars often identify *Succoth* with Tell el-Maskhuta. The mention of 600,000 men in [Numbers 1:46](#) suggests about 2.5 million people in total.

If this large number is literal, it presents some challenges:

1. The camp area would cover 643 square kilometers (400 square miles).
2. A column of people 1,000 wide would stretch nearly a mile and take 20 hours to pass one point.
3. No other known armies in the ancient Near East were this large.

Scholars suggest two possible explanations:

1. The number might be symbolic, showing that God greatly blessed Israel. Although unusual to us, this was acceptable in the ancient world.
2. The Hebrew word for "thousand" (*'elep*) might actually be "troop" (*'allup*). If so, it originally meant "600 troops of fighting men." With each troop having about 100 men, the total population would be much smaller.

Despite the logistical issues, it is possible there were indeed 2.5 million Israelites.

Exodus 12:38

A rabble of non-Israelites: Some of these people later became disaffected and led the Israelites into complaining about their difficulties (see [Num 11:4](#)). We are never told their motivation for joining with the Israelites. Perhaps some had come to faith in the Lord as a result of the plagues. Others probably saw it as an opportunity for a better life elsewhere.

Exodus 12:40

According to the Septuagint and the Samaritan Pentateuch, 430 years would cover the full period from the promise to Abraham ([Gen 12](#); [15](#)) until the

Exodus. Cp. [Gal 3:17](#); see further Exodus Book Introduction, The Date of the Exodus.

Exodus 12:43-50

These extra instructions for celebrating Passover mainly refer to outsiders and foreigners ([12:43](#); [12:48](#)). The presence of non-Israelite groups in the community might have led to these rules ([12:38](#)). The main point was whether the person was willing to fully join Israel and obey the Lord by being circumcised.

Exodus 12:46

do not break any of its bones: The apostle John makes reference to this instruction regarding the Passover lambs when reporting that Jesus' legs were not broken on the cross ([John 19:36](#)).

Exodus 12:51

The Israelites left Egypt in an orderly way, like a large army. The Lord led them as their commander and leader.

Exodus 13:1-10

This review of the customs for Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread prepares the way for teaching about the dedication of the firstborn ([13:11-16](#)).

Exodus 13:1-16

Like the Passover celebration, the dedication of the firstborn helped the people remember what God did during the Passover. God spared the firstborn sons of Israel. Because of this, those firstborn sons belonged to him and had to be redeemed (bought back with a price).

Each year, the people sacrificed and ate a lamb. This act pointed forward to what God would do by giving his Son, Jesus Christ, as a substitute. All people deserve death because of sin. But God redeems them through a price, the life of his Son.

Exodus 13:5

a land flowing with milk and honey: This describes a land that is rich and good for farming. There is grass for cattle to eat, and there are many plants and flowers. From these flowers, bees can make honey.

Exodus 13:9

The annual celebration of the Passover was a visible sign to identify oneself as the Lord's possession. It was a mark of his ownership, the physical reinforcement of a spiritual reality. • Let it remind you always to recite this teaching of the Lord: The second part of the verse may be interpreted either as a statement to be recited (as in the NLT text) or simply as a description of the Lord's work.

Exodus 13:13

A firstborn son had to be bought back, or redeemed. He could not be sacrificed to the Lord, as child sacrifice is condemned throughout Scripture (see [Lev 18:21](#); [20:2](#); [Ezek 23:37-39](#)).

Exodus 13:16

Like the annual Passover celebration ([13:9](#)), dedicating the firstborn to the Lord was like a mark, a visible way to identify oneself as the Lord's possession.

Exodus 13:17-18

faced with a battle: The Israelites had not yet seen God fight on their behalf. Even though they left Egypt like an army ready for battle ([13:18](#); see also [12:51](#)), it was only an appearance. Until they experienced the Lord as fighting for them ([14:14](#)) in the crossing of the sea, they were not ready to face enemies in the Promised Land.

Exodus 13:17-14.4

The Lord's redemptive power was demonstrated as he brought Israel into a place where they were completely helpless and had to either rely on him

for rescue or die. Although at the time it must have seemed completely foolish, Israel would thank God for the rest of its history for maneuvering them into such a spot (see [Ps 106:7-12](#); cp. [Isa 12:2-6](#)).

Exodus 13:18

roundabout way: There is disagreement among scholars about the identification of some of the sites mentioned ([13:20](#); [14:2](#)), so there is little consensus about the precise route the Israelites took. • Red Sea: Literally *sea of reeds*. The Red Sea proper is too far south. The Sea of Reeds was part of the Red Sea, probably located at the northern end of the Gulf of Suez.

Exodus 13:19

Joseph had recognized that God would not leave his people in Egypt indefinitely because he had promised Canaan to them (see [Gen 50:24-25](#)).

Exodus 13:20

The locations of Succoth and Etham are uncertain, although the reference to the edge of the wilderness suggests that they were in the region southeast of the Nile delta toward the Gulf of Suez.

Exodus 13:21

The pillar of cloud and the pillar of fire were to be the Israelites' constant companions for the next forty years.

Exodus 14:2

The precise locations of Pi-hahiroth, Migdol, and Baal-zephon are unknown. • the sea: See study note on 13:18.

Exodus 14:4

know that I am the Lord: This event was the climactic demonstration of the Lord's character and power in the Exodus. Rescue for humans is by means of God's self-revelation as he incarnates

himself in our life and experience. • as they were told: In this part of the book, the Israelites were obedient to God's commands ([12:35](#), [50](#)). Unfortunately, this was not their continued pattern after the crossing.

Exodus 14:5-14

Because there was no real repentance on the part of Pharaoh and his officials, once the immediate terror of their experience had worn off, their self-interest reasserted itself and they determined to recapture their slave labor.

Exodus 14:6-7

chariot: At this point in history, the Egyptian light chariot was the ultimate weapon. Pulled by three horses, it was swift and highly maneuverable. Sometimes it was manned by only one person, but some ancient illustrations show a driver with a warrior. The reference to a commander may indicate such two-man teams. The greatest military power in the world of that day was being marshaled against the Hebrews.

Exodus 14:9

Even though today we don't know exactly where these events took place (see study note on 14:2), there is no question that the narrator and his readers did. We need not conclude that this account is literary fantasy.

Exodus 14:10-12

This complaint is the first occurrence of what was to become a sad refrain over the next forty years. Instead of believing that the God who had demonstrated his power so overwhelmingly could now save them, the Israelites turned on their rescuer. The cry of the unsundered heart is always, "Give me the security of slavery rather than the risk of faith."

Exodus 14:13-14

One person, at least, had learned the lesson of the plagues and applied it to this crisis of faith. Moses

did not know what God would do, but in one of the great statements of faith in the Bible, Moses declared his confidence in God. It was not the Lord who would fail, but the Egyptians.

Exodus 14:15-31

The escape through the Red Sea was the climactic moment of rescue. It was the highest point of God's saving work in the exodus from Egypt.

Exodus 14:17

My great glory: The Hebrew word translated "glory" (*kabod*) connotes weightiness, significance, and reality. God demonstrated his authenticity while showing that all the political, military, and material glory of one of the greatest human cultures was only the thinnest of veils.

Exodus 14:19-25

Whereas the Hebrews had been in a panic the night before, now the highly disciplined Egyptian army was thrown into disarray. They knew they were dealing with something far beyond their ability to comprehend or control.

Exodus 14:22

As with the plagues, naturalistic explanations for this event are beside the point. A strong, steady wind blowing across a relatively shallow, contained body of water can change its depth dramatically, but that does not produce dry ground, with walls of water on each side. The Lord can intervene in nature and do with it as he wishes.

Exodus 14:25

He twisted their chariot wheels: The ancient versions differ on the translation of this phrase. Perhaps there was deep sand where the water had been, and this broke the light wheels of the chariots. At any rate, the Egyptian charge through the sea failed, and they became terrified. • The Lord is fighting for them: Certainly by this time everyone in Egypt was aware of the special relationship between the Lord and his people.

Exodus 14:31

Finally, the people of Israel were moved to put their faith in the Lord: Sadly, it was very short-lived (see [15:24](#); [16:3](#)). • To be the Lord's servant is a position of high honor (see [Isa 42:1-4](#); [Matt 12:18](#)).

Exodus 15:1

Moses and the people: In this triumphant moment there was no division between them; they sang as one. • I will sing: The highly personal declarations of the first two verses emphasize the personal nature of God's relation to humans. He is not an impersonal force, but relates to us as one person relates to another. The songs of thanks and hymns of praise in the Bible characteristically give the reason for the thanks or praise early in the piece (see [Ps 95:1-3](#); [96:1-4](#)). The reason for the song is that the Lord . . . has triumphed gloriously. The community's faith in God through the dark night had been dramatically vindicated.

Exodus 15:1-5

God's salvation (deliverance) and rescue had meaning for personal faith.

Exodus 15:1-18

Scholars believe this song of rescue to be one of the oldest preserved examples of the Hebrew language, attesting to its importance in Israel's thought and faith. It is divided into three stanzas: [15:1-5](#), [6-12](#), [13-18](#). The first stanza rejoices in the Lord's personal rescue of Moses and his people (note the recurrence of the first-person pronouns). The second exults in the great contrast between the Lord and the Egyptians. The third stanza reflects on what these events would mean for the future.

Exodus 15:2

This statement is quoted in two other places, [Ps 118:14](#) and [Isa 12:2](#), which shows its importance. The "God of your father" ([Exod 3:6](#)) had become my God. The Israelites now knew God for themselves and not just as a historical memory.

Exodus 15:3

The Lord is a warrior: He will aggressively defend his own. He is not an oppressor, nor does he fight for the love of violence. But when his people are helpless before the enemy, whether external or internal, they can know that Yahweh, “He Who Is,” is their defender ([Isa 59:15–19](#); [63:1–6](#); [Rev 11:17–18](#)). Regarding the name *Yahweh*, see study note on Exod 3:15.

Exodus 15:6

Your right hand: This was usually the arm a warrior used to hold a sword.

Exodus 15:6–12

The personal tone continues as the Lord is referred to as you and is contrasted dramatically with them ([15:7](#)). All that the enemy intended ([15:9](#)) was brought to nothing ([15:10](#)) before the mighty power of God.

Exodus 15:8

blast (literally *nostrils*): In other contexts, the same word may be translated “anger.” The hot breath from God’s nose is an image of God’s anger. • your breath: The Hebrew word translated as “breath” (*ruakh*) is the same one translated as “wind” in [14:21](#) and as “Spirit” in [Gen 1:2](#). Nature is not God, but God is everywhere at work in nature.

Exodus 15:9–10

Compared to the Creator’s plans, all the plans of even the most powerful humans are nothing (see [Ps 2:2–5](#)). They are like dust that can be blown away with one puff of his breath (see [Isa 40:15–17](#)).

Exodus 15:11

The gods of the pagan nations are not in the same category as the Lord. They do not deserve to be called holy (see study note on 3:5).

Exodus 15:13

In light of God’s unfailing love and his might, there is no reason to doubt that he will be able to keep his promises. “Unfailing love” is a translation of the Hebrew word *khesed*, which speaks of the undeserved kindness and loyalty of a superior to an inferior. It is the most frequent descriptor of God’s character in the Old Testament (see [Ps 136](#)). If God had such a character but did not have the might to carry out his good intentions toward his people, his character would be of little value to us. The good news is that he has both a loving character and all power. • sacred home: God has chosen his people and gathered them to himself in order to dwell in their midst (see also [Exod 15:17](#)).

Exodus 15:13–18

The people God has redeemed have confidence for the future. In light of what the Lord had done in rescuing Israel from his enemies, there was no question that he would be able to carry through on his promise to take them safely into the Promised Land.

Exodus 15:14–15

Philistia, Edom, Moab, and Canaan are the four peoples that would most feel the hand of God’s judgment as he dispossessed them to give the land to the people of Israel. What God had done to Egypt would have been common news throughout that part of the world (see Rahab’s report in [Josh 2:9–11](#), where the same imagery as in [Exod 15:15](#), to melt away, is used).

Exodus 15:17

your own mountain: Deities were believed to have their residence on mountains. Thus Canaan is figuratively portrayed as God’s residence.

Exodus 15:19–21

Miriam led the women in praise. In many ancient societies, men and women performed ceremonies

separately. Women had special roles in ritual praise and lamentation.

Exodus 15:22-27

First at Marah and then at Elim, God provided water for the people. • The precise location of the desert of Shur ([15:22](#)) is unknown.

Exodus 15:22-18.27

On the journey from the sea to Sinai, God continued his providential care for the people's needs. In the events of rescue, he primarily revealed his power. Here he revealed that he cares about his people's basic needs.

Exodus 15:23

The water likely had a high level of natural minerals, which made it taste bitter. This is common in the Sinai Desert.

Exodus 15:24

Instead of reflecting on the lessons of faith so recently experienced, the people lost heart and began to complain, as we often do under adverse circumstances. If this complaining becomes a pattern, disaster can befall us in the ultimate test, as it did the Israelites (see [Num 14](#); [Ps 95:7-11](#); [Heb 3:7-11](#)).

Exodus 15:25

See [2 Kings 2:19-22](#) for a similar event.

Exodus 15:26

The connection between obedience to God's commands and health is not arbitrary. God made the body, and our bodies will last longer if we follow the Creator's guidelines. Since this statement was made in the context of a need for water, it might indicate that the Egyptians had been drinking polluted water.

Exodus 16:1-36

God demonstrated care for his people by providing manna and quail as food for them.

Exodus 16:2

grumbled: The people often showed their lack of faith by complaining.

Exodus 16:3

all the bread we wanted: The Israelites had been oppressed slaves in Egypt! One of the great dangers of complaining is that it blinds us to reality. Faith is grateful for what is, and believes the best is yet to come. Complaining focuses on what is wrong with the present and glorifies an unreal past.

Exodus 16:4-5

These are the Lord's instructions for gathering the food that he would provide in the wilderness. Enough was provided for each day, with a double amount provided on the sixth day so that the people would not have to gather any on the Sabbath (see [16:21-30](#)). The Israelites thus observed the Sabbath even before it was codified in the Decalogue. We instinctively resist a style of life in which it is necessary to depend on God each day to supply our needs. We wish to have supplies in advance so that we can feel independent. God was training the people for a life of faith (cp. [Matt 6:11](#)).

Exodus 16:7

The Hebrew word translated glory connotes weightiness, substance, and reality. It is not the flimsy, ephemeral quality we often associate with the English term *glory*. It is more the idea of royal grandeur.

Exodus 16:15

The Hebrew man hu' (What is it?) came to be the name of the miraculous food ("manna," see [16:31](#)). For forty years, the people ate *what is it?* Jesus referred to himself as the fulfillment of the meaning

of this miracle. He was the “true bread from heaven” that gives life ([John 6:32–35](#), [48](#), [51](#), [63](#)).

Exodus 16:19–20

For these instructions, see study note on 16:4–5.

Exodus 16:21–30

Although the Sabbath was a day set apart for the Lord ([16:23](#)), it was also the Lord’s gift to his people ([16:29](#)). Rest and worship are not meant to be an obligation, but a privilege. However, given the human determination to meet our needs in our own way, rest and worship are given as commands ([16:28](#)).

Exodus 16:32–36

The container of manna was to be preserved as a reminder of God’s providential care for his people. He is powerful and deeply caring. Not only can he supply our needs, he wants to do so.

Exodus 16:35

until they arrived at the land: God’s care for us is normally demonstrated in ordinary ways, as it would usually be for Israel after they arrived in Canaan (see [Josh 5:10–12](#)). That care is just as real as when it comes in extraordinary ways, as it did while Israel was in the wilderness.

Exodus 17:1

from place to place: With a large and diverse group, travel was undoubtedly slow and arduous. It is also possible that God was using this time to demonstrate his care by miraculously providing for their needs before bringing them to Mount Sinai and offering his covenant to them.

Exodus 17:2

testing the Lord is explained in [17:7](#). They doubted that God was really with them or cared for them, and they demanded that he prove his presence and

care. God invites a test based on faith (“I do believe, but help me overcome my unbelief,” [Mark 9:24](#)), but he abhors a test based on doubt (i.e., *I don’t believe, and I think God should prove himself to me*, as in [John 6:30](#)). The test based on doubt makes us the judge and God the defendant.

Exodus 17:3

For a similar complaint, see study note on 16:3.

Exodus 17:6

Mount Sinai: See study note on 3:1. • water gushed out: Note the similar provision in [Num 20:11](#) (see also [Ps 78:15–16](#); [105:41](#); [114:8](#); [Isa 48:21](#)).

Exodus 17:8

Amalek was Esau’s grandson ([Gen 36:11–12](#)). His descendants were nomadic, though loosely based in the land of Edom. They seem to have supported themselves by raiding more settled peoples.

Exodus 17:8–16

Israel defeated the Amalekites only because God blessed them and took care of them.

Exodus 17:9

Joshua was Moses’ trusted assistant ([33:11](#)) who would eventually become his successor ([Deut 31:7–8](#)). This early experience was important training for leading the people later in the conquest of the land. The Hebrew name *Joshua*, which means “savior,” is equivalent to the Greek name *Jesus* (see also study note on Heb 4:8).

Exodus 17:9–13

This victory was a gift from God, as the description here makes clear. The determining factor was God’s blessing, as indicated by Moses’ upraised hands. This principle was illustrated again and again in the conquest of the land of Canaan.

Without God's blessing, Israel could do nothing (see [Num 14:42-45](#); [Josh 7:10-12](#)).

Exodus 17:14-16

By their unprovoked attack on the people through whom God was extending his blessing, the Amalekites incurred the unending wrath of God. God's hand can be extended in blessing, or it can be extended in curse. Those who reject the hand of blessing experience the curse (see [1 Sam 15](#)).

Exodus 17:15

This banner was a battle flag. In [Isa 5:26](#), God lifted up a banner to call the nations to war against Israel. In [Isa 11:10, 12](#), the Messiah would be the banner calling the nations to bring his people home.

Exodus 17:16

They have raised their fist against the Lord's throne, so now: The NLT sees the fist raised against the Lord's throne as Amalek's aggression against the Lord and his people. The alternate interpretation sees a reference to Moses' own hands that were lifted to the Lord in prayer ([17:15](#)).

Exodus 18:1-12

Moses had apparently sent his wife and children back from Egypt at some point to stay with his father-in-law. In the intense confrontation with Pharaoh, Moses might have been afraid for their lives. Jethro now came to meet Moses and the Israelites, bringing Moses' family with him ([18:2-6](#)). In the context of the visit, Moses gave him a report, and Jethro was brought to faith through the testimony of the Lord's work.

Exodus 18:7

bowed low and kissed him. They asked about each other's welfare: These were all typical customs of greeting in that society.

Exodus 18:13-16

Moses had begun to take a role similar to Pharaoh's. He was making himself necessary for every decision the people faced.

Exodus 18:13-27

Jethro's wise advice is a further example of God's providence, although it was not given in a miraculous way. Jethro introduced Moses to a style of leadership that involved delegation of authority. It appears that Moses had been following an Egyptian style of leadership that was heavily hierarchical and based on circumstances. No Egyptian law code has yet been discovered. It appears that all authority flowed downward from the pharaoh, who ruled by fiat. Jethro proposed a structure of delegation that would make Moses' life easier.

Exodus 18:17-18

Such a leader-centered approach is not good for either the leader or the people (see also [18:23](#)).

Exodus 18:19-22

Moses needed to distinguish between his teaching function, in which he received and declared God's decrees and instructions ([18:19-20](#)), and his administrative function, in which he applied all of those decrees and instructions ([18:21-22](#)).

Exodus 19:1

Exactly two months after the Israelites left Egypt: It was now the fifteenth day of the third month.

Exodus 19:1-9

God prepared his people to receive the covenant by first reminding them of the past and of what they had learned about him ([19:4](#)). He then made promises concerning the future, which were contingent upon obedience ([19:5-6](#)). The final result was their promise to obey what the Lord has commanded ([19:8](#)).

Exodus 19:2

The arrival at Sinai was a fulfillment of the promise made earlier to Moses at this same spot ([3:12](#)).

Exodus 19:3

the family of Jacob . . . the descendants of Israel: The link between Jacob and the present generation reflected continuity with the past. God had kept all his promises thus far, and the promises he was yet to make would be equally trustworthy.

Exodus 19:5–6

God, to whom all the earth belongs, promised to make Israel his own special treasure. This promise was contingent upon their accepting a covenant with God and keeping it faithfully. • my kingdom of priests, my holy nation: The nation was to become intermediaries between a holy God and a lost world. Through them God would reveal himself (see [1 Pet 2:9–10](#)).

Exodus 19:7–8

The first phase of preparation was successful. The people agreed to do everything the Lord has commanded.

Exodus 19:9

See also [Deuteronomy 4:12](#) and [33](#).

Exodus 19:10–15

In the second phase of preparation, the people received commands that would prepare them to receive God's covenant. They were to wash their clothing ([19:10, 14](#)) because God is pure. They were to prepare a boundary all around the mountain ([19:12–13](#)) and be careful not to cross it because God is holy. They were to abstain from having sexual intercourse ([19:15](#)) because God is not a sexual being, and his blessings are not produced through sexual activity. Things that are natural and right under ordinary circumstances

were to be set aside for the extraordinary purpose of concentrating on the Lord, the King who was about to appear before the people. Only their compliance with the second of these commands is specifically reported ([19:23](#)), but it is safe to assume that they obeyed the other two as well since no negative response from the Lord is recorded. • [Hebrews 12:18–22](#) contrasts this experience at Mount Sinai with the believer's experience at Mount Zion, "the heavenly Jerusalem."

Exodus 19:16–25

The final phase of preparation involved phenomena that moved the people toward acceptance of the covenant. Some of the experiences were visual: lightning and a cloud ([19:16](#)), smoke and fire ([19:18](#)). The people also heard thunder, a ram's horn, and the voice of God ([19:16, 19](#)), and the whole mountain shook violently ([19:18](#)). In the Bible, such phenomena are often associated with a *theophany*, which is a visible manifestation of God's holy presence.

Exodus 19:21–25

The repeated warnings that no one should break through to approach the Lord reinforced the impact of the phenomena the people had just witnessed. God is utterly transcendent, and he must be approached in the way he ordains or not at all.

Exodus 20:1

This corresponds to the introductory statement in the ancient covenant format. • all these instructions (literally *all these words*): When these statements are referred to elsewhere ([34:28](#); [Deut 4:13](#); [10:4](#)), the Hebrew text refers to them as the "Ten Words." These are not arbitrary commandments, but an explanation of God's basic instructions for human living given by the Creator of human life.

Exodus 20:1–17

This is a short summary of the terms of the covenant (see also [Deuteronomy 5:6–21](#)).

Exodus 20:1–23:33

The Sinai covenant follows very closely the form of the covenants, or *suzerain-vassal* treaties, that great kings (the *suzerains*) in the ancient Near East offered to subject peoples (the *vassals*) as follows: (1) An introduction named the great king who was offering the covenant ([20:1](#)). (2) A historical preamble set out the circumstances that had led to the offer of a treaty ([20:2](#)). (3) Stipulations, the terms upon which the two parties were to agree, typically included the king's offer of protection from enemies and care during emergency, while the people would agree to behave in conformity to the preferences of that king. Exodus includes a brief setting forth of the terms of the covenant ([20:3–17](#)) followed by expanded terms (chs [21–23](#)). (4) Another statement indicated where a written copy of the covenant should be kept and when it should be read ([24:7](#); [25:16](#)). (5) The gods were called upon to witness the agreement (in Exodus, historical markers are substituted for the gods, [24:4](#)). (6) The blessings and curses were stated that would follow upon obedience or disobedience to the covenant ([23:20–33](#)). Utilizing the political form of the covenant, God invited his people into a formal relationship with himself as king while avoiding the pagan overtones that contaminated religious forms of the time. Jesus' Sermon on the Mount ([Matt 5:1–7:29](#)) is a New Testament parallel to this section of Exodus, with the Beatitudes ([Matt 5:3–12](#)) paralleling the Ten Commandments.

Exodus 20:2

This sentence corresponds to the preamble in the ancient covenant format. It gives the historical setting that makes such an agreement between two parties both possible and reasonable. We are told that the Lord your God was offering the covenant. It was not some unknown deity that offered this special relationship, but the God of Israel's ancestors who had revealed his power and his care directly to them. Furthermore, that revelation was an act of gracious rescue on their behalf, demonstrating that he is the only God.

Exodus 20:3

Not recognizing any other god is the first step toward learning the truth that there are no other

gods besides the Lord (see [Deut 4:35](#); [6:4](#); [Isa 43:10–11](#); [45:21–22](#)).

Exodus 20:3–11

The first four commandments relate to one's relationship with God. Observing them would foster a correct understanding of God in contrast to the idolatrous notions of deity that the Israelites had encountered in Egypt and would yet encounter in Canaan.

Exodus 20:3–17

The terms of the covenant specify the behavior the people were expected to manifest if they were to be in a covenant with God. Only the first four instructions ([20:2–11](#)) relate directly to God, while the remaining six ([20:12–17](#)) have to do with human-to-human relationships. A covenant with God stipulates how we are to treat each other because God is profoundly ethical, and he expects us to manifest his character in all our relationships. Other law codes in the ancient Near East did not incorporate such absolute prohibitions, probably because polytheism mitigated against absolute principles. In contrast, covenants with a king did include absolute prohibitions because a single king could demand whatever he wished of his subjects. Here the single king is the sole Creator of the universe, who truly has authority to state absolute principles, demands, and prohibitions.

Exodus 20:4

Not making an image of God is the first step toward recognizing that he is transcendent—that he is the Creator of the universe and distinct from it. To represent God as something in creation was inevitably to end up worshiping the creation rather than the Creator, and this immorality had deadly consequences ([Rom 1:18–25](#)).

Exodus 20:5–6

jealous God: God is passionately opposed to our prostituting ourselves with false gods (see [Josh 24:19–20](#)). • in the third and fourth generations . . . for a thousand generations: It is important to keep both sides of this equation together. God does not

punish children for their parents' sins. Rather, he is saying that our sins affect future generations of descendants. But he is also restricting the natural effects of those sins to three or four generations, while graciously extending the effects of obedience to a thousand generations (see also [34:6-7](#); [Deut 7:9](#)). • reject (literally *hate*): The Hebrew words commonly translated "love" ([Exod 20:6](#)) and "hate" are difficult to translate into English because they include an act of the will as well as the emotional element we are familiar with. In biblical thinking, to "love" is to choose something and to act consistently in accord with that choice. To "hate" is to reject something and to act in ways consistent with that choice. The choice is connected to emotion: Feeling expresses itself in choices, and our choices show how we really feel.

Exodus 20:7

In Hebrew, one's name connotes nature and character (see study note on 3:13-22). To make the name of God empty (NLT, misuse) is to do anything that makes him appear insignificant or worthless. One way to do this is to invoke his name in an oath we do not mean to keep. But there are other, even more significant ways to bring shame on God's name (see [Num 20:12](#); [Amos 2:7](#); cp. [Matt 6:9](#)).

Exodus 20:8-11

The Sabbath day is kept holy when it is dedicated to the Lord ([20:10](#)). Whatever belongs exclusively to God shares his character. This is not to say that the other six days are unholy, but simply that they are for ordinary work ([20:9](#)). On this day set apart, we are reminded that it is not our work that supplies our needs. Our needs are supplied by God as an act of his grace ([20:6](#)).

Exodus 20:11

To be in covenant with God is to do what God does; since he rested from his work ([Gen 2:1-3](#)), how can we think that we need no rest?

Exodus 20:12

To honor your father and mother is to recognize that you are not self-sufficient and self-existent.

This is one important step on the road to humility. Arrogance may produce notoriety, but humility and gratitude are the foundations of a long, full life. Both Jesus and Paul refer to this command (see [Matt 15:4](#); [Mark 7:10](#); [Eph 6:1-3](#)).

Exodus 20:12-17

The remaining six instructions all have to do with human relationships. Many of the stipulations of the covenant with God relate to how people treat each other. This connection of ethical behavior with religious duty is unique in the Old Testament world. There are several ethical law codes known in the ancient Near East, and several of these predate Moses, but all of them are imposed by a human king and have little to do with religion. The pagan gods, meanwhile, were patently unethical and untrustworthy, unlike the God of Israel, whose people worship him by treating others as he does. See also [Matt 19:17-19](#).

Exodus 20:13

murder: This is the correct rendering of the Hebrew word. There is another word that connotes mere killing. Taking human life is not prohibited, per se, but the intentional killing of another for personal reasons is prohibited. This principle tells us that God values our individual, physical lives. Jesus expanded on this command in [Matt 5:21-26](#).

Exodus 20:14

adultery: Here this term represents all sexual sins, among which adultery most clearly indicates breaking faith. Adulterers satisfy their sexual desires as they please, and they break faith with their spouse in so doing. Jesus expanded on this command in [Matt 5:27-30](#).

Exodus 20:15

Stealing is another way of saying that I have an absolute right to my own way, whether I have earned it or not. From the divine side, the prohibition says that God values us even down to our possessions.

Exodus 20:16

Not telling a lie can be a very individual act, and even a prideful one. But refusing to testify falsely against your neighbor is an unselfish act, in which your neighbor's reputation and well-being is more important to you than your own.

Exodus 20:17

This final principle circles back to the first, for "a greedy person is an idolater" ([Col 3:5](#)). Covetousness is the worship of this world, the belief that possessions, especially those my neighbor possesses, will give me lasting happiness. To believe this is to break one's covenant of absolute loyalty to God, who alone supplies our needs. See also [Rom 7:7](#).

Exodus 20:18-21

The people were very conscious of their sinfulness before a holy God and begged Moses to stand between them and God. Moses pointed out that God's goal was neither to overawe them nor to destroy them. Rather, he wanted their awe of him to keep them from sinning ([20:20](#)). Jesus is the ultimate mediator between God and people ([1 Tim 2:5](#)).

Exodus 20:18-26

This interlude is about access to God. The first part ([20:18-21](#)) deals with the need for a mediator between the people and God. In [20:22-26](#), we find the appropriate form for an altar in the interval before God revealed his plans for a more permanent sanctuary (see [25:1-30:28](#)).

Exodus 20:22-26

The Lord is transcendent, as shown by his speaking to the people in a disembodied voice from heaven ([20:22](#)). This would have two effects upon their practice: They were not to use silver or gold to make gods in human form (idols, [20:23](#)), and they were not to carve stones for an altar ([20:25](#)). Perhaps this is because they would be tempted to carve stone gods in the process. The altar was to be made of earth ([20:24](#)) and uncut stones ([20:25](#)). •

The prohibition against revealing one's nakedness ([20:26](#)) might have been to separate Israelite religious practice from the nature worship around them. Sexual activity was an integral part of many Canaanite rituals.

Exodus 21:1-11

Slavery was a fact of life in the ancient world. In some cases, it was the only resort for those who were destitute. In much of the ancient world, people who were slaves felt that the gods had abandoned them. But the Lord cares about those who are in this helpless condition, so his covenant people must care also. Ultimately, the revelation that Jesus Christ had died for all people everywhere would make the practice of slavery untenable ([Gal 3:28](#)).

Exodus 21:1-23.19

The statements found here are in the typical case-law format of ancient Near Eastern law codes. This format begins with a hypothetical situation introduced by the word "if." The following statement of what is to be done in such a case is introduced by "then." While some cases are grouped into categories in these chapters, there is little attempt to separate personal, civil, or ceremonial laws from one another. For God, life is not compartmentalized. All of life is lived in relationship to God, so all kinds of behavior signify whether we are in loving submission to him or in defiance of him.

Exodus 21:1-23.33

The terms of the covenant are now expanded. The beginning section ([21:1-23:19](#)) gives specific examples of the general principles stated in [20:3-17](#). The commitments to which God bound himself if the Israelites kept their side of the covenant are stated in [23:20-33](#), as are the blessings of obedience.

Exodus 21:2

A man might sell himself into slavery in order to get money to pay his debts. This law states that the

man was never to become the permanent property of the master.

Exodus 21:3

If a man and a wife went into slavery together, they were also to go free together.

Exodus 21:4–6

The master was not required to provide a slave with a wife who would then be freed with him. The slave in such a situation had to either abandon the family he began while he was a slave or become a permanent slave.

Exodus 21:7–9

A female slave was treated differently from a male, possibly because it was understood that she was sold to become a concubine. For such a woman to be released after seven years would not be just. She would either have to return to her father (who clearly did not want her, having previously sold her), marry (an unlikely prospect for a former concubine), or become a prostitute. Thus, it was best for her to remain in the home of her master. Presumably, if a man bought a girl to be his son's wife ([21:9](#)), it was understood that the purchase price was not actually buying her but was the equivalent of a bride-price. Typically, a young man wishing to marry a girl had to give her father a gift of some sort, either money or a gift in kind (see [22:16](#); [Gen 24:53](#)). A woman for whom a bride-price had been paid was not a slave.

Exodus 21:12–17

The crimes of murder, kidnapping, and dishonoring one's parents warranted the death penalty. A murderer forfeits his own life, and human life is so precious that even an accidental death cannot be overlooked. The place of refuge (see [Num 35:6–28](#)) was a place where an accidental killer could go so that the family of the deceased could not take vengeance (see study notes on Num 35:6–34).

Exodus 21:14

take him away from My altar: See [1 Kings 2:28–33](#).

Exodus 21:17

Anyone who dishonors: See study note on Lev 20:9; see also [Exod 20:12](#); [Deut 5:16](#); [21:18–21](#); [Eph 6:1–4](#).

Exodus 21:18–27

These laws governed compensation for injuries that did not lead to death.

Exodus 21:22–25

so she gives birth prematurely: It appears that if a child's birth was caused prematurely and the child died (i.e., there was further injury), the penalty for murder was to be enacted. The law of retaliation (the *lex talionis*) called for a penalty that matched the injury inflicted on a victim. But this law also served to limit the punishment so it was not more severe than the original injury. Cp. [Matt 5:38–39](#).

Exodus 21:28–32

If an animal caused a person's death and the owner was judged to be negligent, the relatives of the deceased could demand the death penalty for both the animal and its owner. However, that penalty was not mandatory, and the relatives could elect to accept compensation ([21:30](#)).

Exodus 21:33–22.15

In cases involving loss of property, the responsible person had to pay compensation equal to the value of what was lost. If the person had actually stolen the property, the compensation was multiplied ([22:1](#), [4](#), [7](#)). Where there was a question of responsibility, the parties were to appear before God for adjudication ([22:8](#)). The means by which the judgment was reached is not reported.

Exodus 22:16–31

These miscellaneous cases involving social responsibility are not categorized. All parts of life are an expression of one's obedience to God (see study note on 21:1–23:19).

Exodus 22:18

The practices of a sorceress represented the pagan worldview from which God was delivering his people. That worldview was utterly incompatible with the biblical one (see [20:3](#); [23:13](#)).

Exodus 22:20

he must be set apart for destruction: See the “Complete Dedication” Theme Note.

Exodus 22:21

The Hebrews were to treat foreigners kindly because they, too, had once been foreigners (see also [23:9](#); [Deut 10:18–19](#)). For further development of the principle, see [Luke 6:31](#).

Exodus 22:22–23

The widow, the orphan, and the foreigner were in a helpless and economically disadvantaged position. God, by his protective stance toward these persons, demonstrated that he does not value people on the basis of their power or wealth, the standards accepted by most humans. Instead, God values people because they share his image ([Gen 1:27](#)).

Exodus 22:25–27

Although interest could not be charged on a loan to another Israelite, collateral, or security, could be required. However, even the security had to be handled in a humane way. The requirements of the covenant mirrored the character of God.

Exodus 22:30

God is considerate even of animals (see [Jonah 4:11](#)).

Exodus 22:31

In the Bible, blood has symbolic meaning because it represents life. For this reason, God forbade people to eat meat that still had blood in it (see [Leviticus 17:10–16](#)).

Exodus 23:1–3

It is necessary to give true witness, even under the pressure of evil people ([23:1](#)), the crowd ([23:2](#)), or misguided motives ([23:3](#), [7–8](#)).

Exodus 23:1–9

This call for justice includes a miscellaneous list of covenant requirements, most of which have to do with fairness and integrity.

Exodus 23:7

God's character inspires people to act righteously (see [22:22–24](#), [27](#)).

Exodus 23:10–12

Renewal, rest ([23:12](#)), and refreshment are important. Just as humans and animals are to enjoy these in the weekly Sabbath, so the land is to be given rest every seven years ([23:10–11](#); see study note on 20:8–11).

Exodus 23:14–17

God commanded that every man in Israel must appear before him three times each year ([23:17](#)). They must appear at the tabernacle (also called the *Tent of Meeting*). While Israel camped around the Tent of Meeting in the wilderness, this command was not difficult to obey. The people lived close to the tabernacle.

Later, after Israel settled in the promised land, many people lived far from the Tent of Meeting and later from the temple in Jerusalem. Travel became longer and more demanding.

This command was likely meant to prevent the people from building local worship centers. If each region created its own place of worship, the nation could become divided.

Local shrines could also allow pagan influences (beliefs and practices from other religions) to enter the worship of Yahweh. By gathering at one central place, the people would remain united in their worship of the one true God.

Sadly, the people did not always carry out these commands carefully (see, for example, [2 Kings 23:21-23](#)).

Exodus 23:15

At the appointed time in the month of Abib: See [13:4-5](#); [Leviticus 23:5-8](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1-8](#).

Exodus 23:16

The Festival of Harvest was celebrated seven weeks after Passover, around the end of the barley harvest and the beginning of the wheat harvest (mid-May to mid-June). In postbiblical Judaism, this festival commemorated the giving of the Sinai covenant, which was calculated to have occurred fifty days after the first Passover in Egypt (see [Lev 23:15-21](#); [Deut 16:9-12](#)). • The Festival of the Final Harvest was celebrated on the fifteenth day of the seventh month of the Hebrew calendar (mid-September to mid-October), after the final harvest of grapes was complete. This festival commemorated the wilderness wanderings when God provided for his people.

Exodus 23:18

Blood symbolized life ([Lev 17:11-14](#); [Deut 12:23](#)), so blood must not be mixed with yeast, which was not normally included in offerings (see study note on [Lev 2:11](#)). • The fat, considered the best part of the offering, was to be burned at once (see [Lev 3:3-5](#)).

Exodus 23:19

The significance of the command not to cook a young goat in its mother's milk is unknown. Its

inclusion at this point suggests that it may have been a pagan religious practice.

Exodus 23:20-23

an angel: Probably "the angel of the LORD," often representing God himself (see [3:2](#)).

Exodus 23:20-33

If the people obeyed the covenant rules, God promised to protect them from enemies and illness and give them land to own ([23:22-23](#), [25-26](#), [27-31](#)). These promises depended on complete loyalty to God (Yahweh). Worshiping the gods of the peoples expelled from the land would be an act of rebellion ([23:21](#); [24](#), [32-33](#)).

Exodus 23:24

In Canaanite worship, people built holy pillars to represent the gods. Sometimes, they carved them to look like humans.

Exodus 23:26

Pagan rites were carried out in an attempt to manipulate the forces of fertility and reproduction. God promised to give these gifts freely if the people would faithfully carry out the terms of their covenant with him.

Exodus 23:29-31

I will: God, not Israel, would take the land. The land would be a gift from their Covenant Lord. Israel was being granted possession of it as long as they faithfully fulfilled the covenant.

Exodus 23:31

from the eastern wilderness to the Euphrates River: See [Gen 15:18](#); [Num 34:2-12](#); [Deut 11:24](#); [2 Chr 9:26](#). • I will hand over to you the people: God had promised the land to Abraham ([Gen 15:16](#)). At that time, "the sins of the Amorites" had not yet run their course. Now they had. God was not arbitrarily

dispossessing the Amorites (i.e., the Canaanites) but was using his people, the Israelites, to judge their wickedness.

Exodus 23:33

they will cause you to sin against me: The Canaanites were to be destroyed because there could be no truce between a holy God and sin. Furthermore, the continuance of God's revelation, which was to culminate in the incarnation of Jesus Christ, depended on the survival of that revelation through the people of Israel. If they fell back into paganism, that could not happen.

Exodus 24:1-2

Some commentators suggest that Moses, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu, and the elders made two trips up the mountain, here and in [24:9-11](#). However, this command was probably given in advance and obeyed at the proper time in [24:9](#).

Exodus 24:1-18

Israel agreed to the terms of the covenant ([24:3](#)), which was then ratified in several ceremonial activities. This included the formal writing and reading of the covenant ([24:4, 7](#)), the splattering of blood ([24:6](#)), a covenant meal ([24:11](#)), and the appearing of the glory of the Lord on the mountain ([24:15-18](#)).

Exodus 24:3

went down: At this critical moment, would the people accept this relationship with God in which they would swear absolute loyalty to him and agree to live in ways that are in keeping with his character? Fortunately, they answered unanimously, with one voice, that they would abide by the covenant.

Exodus 24:4

Pillars were erected as historical markers, witnessing in history that something momentous had occurred at a certain time at this place. In Hittite treaties, pagan gods were called upon to

witness the agreement. In this case, the Hebrews were forbidden to recognize other gods, so pillars served the purpose.

Exodus 24:6

When Moses splattered half of the blood of the sacrificial animals against the altar, he symbolized God's formal oath to keep the covenant (see [Gen 15:9-18](#); [Heb 6:13](#)).

Exodus 24:7

Treaties were required to be written down and publicly read . . . aloud. Very likely Moses began at this time to write down, under God's inspiration, all the things that he believed were authoritative documents for his people.

Exodus 24:8

Look, this blood confirms the covenant (literally *behold the blood of the covenant*): Jesus repeated this sentence almost verbatim at the Last Supper ([Matt 26:28](#)), when he said, "This is my blood, which confirms the covenant" (literally "*This is my blood of the covenant*"). See also [Heb 9:20](#).

Exodus 24:10

There they saw . . . God: This statement must be interpreted in the light of [33:20](#). They saw some representation of God, the description of which is limited to the surface under his feet. When Isaiah saw God, the only description given was of the hem of his robe ([Isa 6:1](#)).

Exodus 24:11

In places around the world, eating a meal together often indicates peace and good relationships. This is true both in the past and today.

Exodus 24:12

The instructions and commands to be inscribed on the tablets of stone were the ten basic principles of

[20:3-17](#) (see [34:28](#)) on which the specific stipulations of [21:1-23:33](#) depended.

Exodus 24:17

consuming fire: See [3:2](#) and the study note.

Exodus 25:1-27.19

These instructions first indicate the materials the Israelites could contribute for the construction of the Tabernacle ([25:3-7](#)). The instructions then move from the center outward, beginning with the Ark of the Covenant ([25:10-22](#)) and concluding with the courtyard ([27:9-19](#)). Two items, the altar of incense in the sanctuary and the washbasin in the courtyard, are included later ([30:1-10](#), [17-21](#)), in the section relating to the priesthood, perhaps because their use was especially related to functions of the priests.

Exodus 25:1-40.38

Unlike our churches, the Tabernacle functioned primarily as a residence or palace of God, the divine king, rather than as a place for people to congregate. In this respect, churches are more like the later Jewish synagogues (see also study note on 40:2). This last section of Exodus completes the revelation of God necessary for the people of Israel to come out of the theological darkness that had held them in bondage. This final section includes instructions for building the Tabernacle (chs [25-31](#)), the story of the gold calf (a wrong attempt to secure God's presence, chs [32-34](#)), and the report of building the Tabernacle (the proper way to secure God's presence, chs [35-40](#)). God's ultimate goal in delivering the people from bondage was to share his presence with them. Because of his holiness, that presence could only be experienced in his way, not through the pagan way of human manipulation. The construction of the Tabernacle is reported here, even though some of the instructions in Leviticus were actually given before this event (see [40:1-2](#); [Lev 25:1](#); [27:34](#); [Num 7:1](#)). This event expresses the goal of the entire Exodus sequence, which is God taking up residence among his people.

Exodus 25:2

all whose hearts are moved: There is a marked difference in motivation between meeting needs in God's way and attempting to meet them in our own way, as when Aaron used coercion in creating the gold calf (see [32:1-4](#)).

Exodus 25:8

a holy sanctuary: If the people were to have a life-giving relationship with God, it was absolutely vital that they learn how utterly different God was from them (see study note on 3:5). • The purpose of this activity was so God could live among them.

Exodus 25:9

exactly according to the pattern: We do not determine for ourselves how we want to come into the presence of a holy God. If we come into his presence at all, it will be on his terms and in accord with his desires and character.

Exodus 25:10-22

an Ark of acacia wood: In translating the plans for the Ark of the Covenant, the NLT continues to use the word Ark because of its traditional associations. However, *ark* is simply an archaic English word meaning "box." The Ark was Israel's "covenant box." It was the most significant item in the whole complex, because it was there that God made his presence available ([25:22](#)). The presence of the stone tablets of the covenant in the box ([25:16](#), [21](#)) underlined the truth that God reveals himself in the context of a mutually binding commitment between himself and his people.

Exodus 25:12-15

The carrying poles were there so that no one would touch this representation of God's devastating holiness. Later, a death occurred when someone instinctively reached out to steady the Ark as it was being moved from one place to another (see [2 Sam 6:6-7](#)).

Exodus 25:17

The word translated atonement means “to cover over.” The cover of the covenant box was the place of “covering over” sin (see [Lev 16:14-16](#)).

Exodus 25:18

The appearance of the cherubim is not described except to say that they had wings ([25:20](#); see [2 Chr 3:10-13](#)).

Exodus 25:22

I will meet with you there: The Ark was located in the innermost part of the sanctuary ([26:33](#)), which was in effect God’s throne room (see study note on [Lev 16:2](#)). In a comparable pagan sanctuary, one would find an idol in this location. The Tabernacle had no idol, only a box that physically represented the covenant faithfulness and grace of God. God meets his people in that context, not in the context of idolatry. An idol reflects the belief that a deity is continuous with the created order and that it can be manipulated with the right ritual. It assumes that we can secure blessings from the deity without regard to our own character or commitment. But God is completely distinct from this world, and he cannot be manipulated in any way. He wants to bless us, but those blessings can only be given to those who receive his grace as a gift and surrender to him in trust.

Exodus 25:23-30

The table of acacia wood stood on the north side of the main room of the sanctuary, the Holy Place ([26:35](#)). It reminded the people that God would provide sustenance for them. Above all, that sustenance was his presence ([25:30](#)).

Exodus 25:29

The drink offerings included olive oil and wine (see [29:40](#)).

Exodus 25:31-39

The lampstand of pure, hammered gold stood on the south side of the Holy Place ([26:35](#)). It showed the light of God’s presence to his people. The lamps ([25:37](#)) were flat dishes containing olive oil. A wick extended into the oil and hung down from a lip on one side of the dish. The dishes, resting on the upturned almond blossoms ([25:33](#)), were to be turned so that all their wicks faced the center of the room ([25:37](#)). The total number of lamps is not clear. Although seven lamps are mentioned in [25:37](#), there seem to be 22 lamp cups in [25:33-34](#).

Exodus 26:1-37

The Tabernacle proper (as distinct from the surrounding courtyard) was not very large. It was approximately 15 feet wide and 45 feet long. The supporting framework consisted of 48 vertical frames, 15 feet high and 27 inches wide ([26:16](#)). They were made of acacia wood overlaid with gold ([26:15, 29](#)). The frames were locked together with horizontal crossbars to form a three-sided rectangle with an open end ([26:26-28](#)). Two large linen curtains (each composed of five smaller ones) were then linked together into one and draped across the top of this framework. The combined total was long enough to hang down on the sides and rear ([26:1-6](#)), forming coverings for the walls as well as the roof. Over the linen curtain was draped a curtain of goat-hair cloth constructed in the same way. It was three feet wider and six feet longer than the linen curtain ([26:7-13](#)), so that it hung down further than the linen curtain on all sides. Over these two curtains were two protective coverings, one of tanned ram skins and one of fine goatskin leather ([26:14](#)). The space so enclosed was divided in two with another beautifully embroidered curtain hanging crosswise on four posts of acacia wood. The resulting two spaces were the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place ([26:31-33](#)).

Exodus 26:2-6

42 feet long and 6 feet wide: A width of 6 feet may have been dictated by the size of the largest loom available. Five of the six-foot strips were joined, probably by being sewn together, making one continuous piece of cloth 42 feet long and 30 feet wide. When joined to each other with the loops and

clasps ([26:5–6](#)), the two cloths formed a single unit 42 feet by 60 feet.

Exodus 26:9

The two goat-hair curtains ([26:7](#)) totaled 45 feet by 66 feet. The extra 6 feet were equally distributed to hang down over the front and back of the framework.

Exodus 26:15

acacia wood: This is a hard wood found in the region of Sinai.

Exodus 26:19

Apparently each of the bases stood beneath the junction where the frames met. The right peg of one frame and the left peg of the next frame went into one base. Along with the crossbars ([26:27–28](#)), this arrangement would contribute to the stability of the whole.

Exodus 26:31

While blue, purple, and scarlet are rich colors appropriate for the palace of a divine king, they may also have been specified because these dyes were easiest to procure in the desert.

Exodus 26:33

The Most Holy Place was the earthly dwelling of the Lord. It contained the Ark of the Covenant, from which the Lord would give his commands for the people of Israel ([25:22](#)). The Most Holy Place was approximately 15 feet wide, 15 feet deep, and 15 feet high.

Exodus 26:36–37

The curtain that covered the opening at the eastern end of the structure was similar to the one separating the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. The bases of these supporting posts were of bronze instead of silver.

Exodus 27:1–8

Like the frames of the Tabernacle, the square altar of burnt offerings was made of acacia wood overlaid with metal. However, in keeping with the other features outside the sanctuary, it was overlaid with bronze ([27:2–3](#); see [27:10](#), [17](#), [19](#)).

Exodus 27:1–19

These plans for the altar of burnt offering and the courtyard continue the movement outward from the center. As with the sanctuary, the plans for the furniture of the courtyard are given ([27:1–8](#)) before the plans for the courtyard itself ([27:9–19](#)).

Exodus 27:2

Archaeology has shown that the horns of the altar were protrusions sticking up from the corners of the structure. Perhaps they kept wood and offerings from falling off (see [Ps 118:27](#)). They also seem to have had a theological significance, representing God's gracious care. A person who held onto the horns of the altar was requesting leniency in judgment (see [1 Kgs 1:50–51](#); [2:28](#)). The horns were anointed with blood in atonement and purification ceremonies ([Exod 29:12](#); [Lev 4:7](#)).

Exodus 27:5

The altar was evidently a hollow square ([27:1](#), [8](#)), with the grating placed inside it to allow ashes to fall to the ground underneath.

Exodus 27:9–19

The plans for the courtyard called for walls of curtains made of finely woven linen hanging on posts with bronze bases. The posts seem to have been 7½ feet apart and 7½ feet high. The curtains formed a rectangle 150 feet long and 75 feet wide, with a 30-foot opening centered in the east.

Exodus 27:16

The curtain shielding the entry to the courtyard was similar in color and workmanship to the entry curtain and the dividing curtain of the Tabernacle ([26:31](#), [36](#)).

Exodus 27:19

The use of tent pegs suggests that the courtyard posts were not freestanding but were stabilized with guy wires.

Exodus 27:20–21

The first thing said about the function of the priests, Aaron and his sons, is that they were to keep the lamps burning continually through the night (see [30:8](#)). As the lamps burned in the Lord's presence, they would indicate the continuity of his presence.

Exodus 27:20–30:38

Following the instructions for Tabernacle structure, instructions are now given for those who would serve in the Tabernacle and for the elements involved in that service. Included are priestly functions ([27:20–21](#); [29:38–46](#)), clothing (ch [28](#)), dedication ceremonies ([29:1–37](#)), furnishings ([30:1–10](#), [17–21](#)), and supplies ([30:11–16](#), [22–38](#)).

Exodus 27:21

the Tent of Meeting: The expression *Tent of Meeting* sometimes refers to the tabernacle tent. In these cases, *Tent of Meeting* and *tabernacle* mean the same thing.

In addition, [33:7–11](#) also mentions a temporary tent called the *Tent of Meeting*. This tent was set up outside the camp before the tabernacle was built. See study note on 40:2.

Exodus 28:1–2

The garments described in this chapter are primarily those for Aaron, the first high priest. The clothing for Aaron's sons, who functioned as his assistants, is described in [28:40–43](#).

Exodus 28:1–43

These glorious and beautiful ([28:2](#)) garments for Aaron were to distinguish him as a priest set apart (Hebrew *qadash*, “consecrated”) for [the Lord's] service ([28:3](#)). The magnificence of these garments is in keeping with the grandeur of the Tabernacle, which functioned as a portable earthly palace for God. There would come a day when Jesus Christ, the true High Priest, would enter the Most Holy Place once for all, and the distinction between priests and people would fade away ([Heb 10:11–22](#)). Until that time, human mediators were needed to symbolize the wonderful thing that God was planning to do in the hearts, lives, and behaviors of those with whom he shared his presence.

Exodus 28:6–14

The ephod was a kind of apron consisting of front and back pieces joined by shoulder straps ([28:7](#)) and secured by a decorative sash ([28:8](#), [27–28](#)). Perhaps it is mentioned first because it was understood to be the distinctive high priestly garment. The fact that Gideon later made a gold ephod ([Judg 8:27](#)) suggests that the garment was thought to have special powers.

Exodus 28:12

names on his shoulders (cp. [Isa 9:6](#)): The badge of office on the shoulder indicated what the person was really carrying. Thus, the high priest represented the people before God, and with his royal garments he represented the glory of God before the people.

Exodus 28:15–30

More attention is given to the chestpiece than to any other item, suggesting the importance attached to it. It apparently symbolized the priest's representation of Israel ([28:17–21](#), [29](#)) and was a container for the Urim and Thummim, by which God made his will known ([28:30](#)). The chestpiece represented the totality of the high priest's tasks of bringing the people to God and bringing God's word to the people.

Exodus 28:29

The high priest would go into the Holy Place (the outer room of the sanctuary) to trim the lamp, replace the bread on the table, and replenish the incense on the altar that stood outside the Most Holy Place.

Exodus 28:30

The Urim and Thummim (Hebrew terms that might translate as *lights* [or *curses*] and *perfections*) were apparently a pair of stones that were thrown down to get a yes or no answer from God. No physical description of these objects exists; their use is further explained in [Num 27:21](#); [Deut 33:8](#); [1 Sam 28:6](#); [Ezra 2:63](#); and [Neh 7:65](#).

Exodus 28:31–35

The robe worn under the ephod is described. The bells signaled that the priest was still moving and had not been struck dead by God's presence (see [Lev 10:1–2](#)). Jewish tradition tells us that the priest had a cord tied to his ankle so that if he died in the Holy Place ([Exod 28:35](#)), his body could be dragged out.

Exodus 28:36–38

Like all the other elements of the high priest's clothing and activities, the medallion worn on the front of the turban was to remind the people that God is holy, and his holiness had implications for their entering his presence. God wished to dwell with his people, but his holiness would destroy them unless he took preventative steps. God determines the way into his presence; we do not. The central question of the Bible is how a sinful people can live in the presence of a holy God so that God can share his holy character with them. Ultimately, the answer is provided in Jesus Christ, the Holy One of God who is the perfect mediator ([Luke 4:34](#); [Heb 9:11–15](#)). He did not die only to rescue us from the consequences of our sin, but so that God can live in us, reproducing his holy character in us ([Eph 2:10](#); [4:22](#); [Phil 1:27](#); [1 Pet 1:13–16](#)).

Exodus 28:39

The tunic was probably a shirt worn under the robe (see [29:5](#)).

Exodus 28:42–43

Expressions of sexuality were a frequent part of pagan religion, as worshipers attempted to control the powers of fertility. In some cases, priests served their deities in the nude. Not even a hint of sexual manipulation was acceptable in the worship of the Lord. His blessings could not be achieved through magical manipulation. Thus, even unintentional display of the genitals was guarded against.

Exodus 29:1

with no defects: The same word is translated “blameless” and “perfect” in reference to human and divine behavior (e.g., [Gen 17:1](#); [Ps 18:30](#), [32](#)). The sacrifice is representative of God's own character and the character he seeks in humans.

Exodus 29:1–37

Moses was required to consecrate (or *sanctify*) Aaron and his sons to serve the Lord. This emphasis on making the priests holy is found throughout the ceremonies ([29:6](#), [21](#), [28](#), [29](#), [34](#), [36](#), [37](#)). They were set apart not merely for service, but to serve a God whose nature is utterly different from that of fallen, sinful humans. The report of how these instructions were carried out is found in [Lev 8](#).

Exodus 29:4

wash them with water: This act dramatized the truth that no one can live in God's presence with the filth of sin in their lives ([29:21](#)).

Exodus 29:7

The anointing oil empowered a person for a task through the Holy Spirit (see [Isa 61:1](#)).

Exodus 29:9

forever: The fulfillment of this promise, as with the one to David, clearly leads beyond the merely human. Aaron's own behavior was less than sterling (e.g., ch [32](#); [Num 11](#)), and the behavior of his sons and descendants was no better ([1 Sam 2:12-17](#); [Isa 28:7](#); [Ezek 8:15-16](#); [Mal 2:1-9](#)). The promise could only find its ultimate fulfillment in Jesus Christ (see [Heb 7:26](#); [9:11](#)). • To ordain (literally *to fill the hands*) means to give a person a task to perform.

Exodus 29:10-34

The consecration of the priesthood of Aaron involved a sin offering ([29:10-14](#)), a burnt offering ([29:15-18](#)), and an ordination offering ([29:19-28](#)). The same patterns established here are expanded to the regular offerings of the people (see [29:38-46](#); [Lev 1-5](#)). In all three cases, Aaron and his sons lay their hands on [the] head of the sacrificial animals ([Exod 29:10, 15, 19](#)), indicating that sin is a matter of life and death, and that it can only be removed by a death. Because it represents life, blood is prominent in these ceremonies ([29:12, 16, 20, 21](#)).

Exodus 29:13

The fat was considered the best part and so was given to God.

Exodus 29:14

- The remains stood for what was unclean in human behavior. They symbolized actions and attitudes that were sinful or morally impure.
- *sin offering*: See [Leviticus 4](#).

Exodus 29:15-18

The next offering was a gift of thanks to God. It also represented fully dedicating oneself to God.

Exodus 29:18

pleasing aroma: Such language is *anthropomorphism*, describing God with human terms and experiences. God's delight in an appropriately offered sacrifice is like a human's enjoyment of a pleasing smell.

Exodus 29:19-28

This ordination offering is very similar to the peace (or fellowship) offering later described in [Lev 3](#). The fat was burned as a gift to the Lord, but the breast and the thigh, after having been dedicated to the Lord by lifting them up before him ([29:24-26](#)), became the portion for the priests to eat ([29:26-28](#)). In the regular peace offering, the remainder of the meat was to be eaten by the person making the offering in a fellowship meal ([Lev 7:11-18](#)), as the priests did here ([Exod 29:31-34](#)).

Exodus 29:20-21

The placing of the blood on the earlobes, thumbs, and big toes represented dedication of the entire person to God. Sprinkling it on their clothes indicated that the clothing, too, could be used only for holy purposes.

Exodus 29:30

The descendant who succeeds him: Each succeeding high priest was to be ordained in the same way.

Exodus 29:31

This holy place was probably in the courtyard of the tabernacle.

Exodus 29:32-34

Eating in the presence of the Lord showed a close relationship with him (as in [24:9-11](#)).

Exodus 29:33

their purification: Or *their atonement*. Traditionally, atonement has been described as a “covering over.” Some more recent commentators seek to derive the term from another Semitic root (which does not occur elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible) and thus arrive at “blot out, erase, or cleanse.” In either case, the effect is the same: Persons and objects are made capable of surviving in God’s presence because of a negation of the effects of their sin.

Exodus 29:37

As with the priests, the altar was to be made holy so it could be used in service of the holy God.

Exodus 29:38–41

Offering the daily sacrifices was one of the chief functions of the priest.

Exodus 29:42–46

The purpose of the Tabernacle, the priesthood, and the sacrificial system was to facilitate human fellowship with God. The Lord would meet with his people there ([29:42](#), [43](#)) and speak with them ([29:42](#)). He would live among them as their God ([29:45](#), [46](#)).

Exodus 29:46

The purpose of the Exodus was to reveal the grace, power, and holiness of God and to enable humans to experience God’s presence in their lives.

Exodus 30:1–10

Plans for the altar of acacia wood are included here rather than with the plans for the other items in the sanctuary ([25:23–40](#)), perhaps because of the reference to the priest’s use of it in [30:7–10](#).

Exodus 30:6

outside the inner curtain: That is, in the Holy Place, just outside the Most Holy Place where the Ark was located. • The rising smoke of the incense symbolized prayer. Believers now have constant access to God in prayer through the continuous atonement provided through Christ (see [Ps 141:2](#); [Luke 1:10](#); [Rev 5:8](#); [8:3–4](#)).

Exodus 30:12

no plague: Cp. [2 Sam 24](#), when a plague followed upon David’s unauthorized census. Perhaps a census was often taken for reasons of pride and domination. Here the people are giving God a ransom for themselves. This standard payment would go into the Tabernacle treasury and initially be used in the construction of the Tabernacle (see [Exod 38:25–26](#)).

Exodus 30:17–21

On why the plans for the bronze washbasin are included here, see study note on 30:1–10.

Exodus 30:22–38

Because God is absolutely unique (holy), what is used for his service cannot be used for any other purpose. This was the point made to Moses at the burning bush (see study note on 3:5). It was so vital for the people to understand this point that disobedience in this matter involved a severe punishment ([30:33](#)).

Exodus 30:33

cut off from his people: Either by death or by expulsion. In some cases, God brought death as a direct judgment. In other cases, the person was removed from the community.

Exodus 31:1–11

God gave instructions for the Tabernacle complex and for those who would serve in it. He also chose and empowered those who would do the work.

Exodus 31:3

I have filled him with the Spirit of God: This is one of the earliest references to being filled with the Spirit as an expression of divine empowerment for activities that are clearly beyond normal human abilities (see also [Gen 41:38](#); [Num 11:17](#); [Judg 6:34](#); [14:19](#); [1 Sam 10:6](#); [16:13](#); [Joel 2:28-29](#); [Mic 3:8](#)).

Exodus 31:6

God commanded remarkable things, but he also provided gifted craftsmen who would be able to carry out all those instructions—much as Augustine prayed, “Give what you command, and command what you will” (Augustine, *Confessions* 10.29).

Exodus 31:11

The point throughout this entire section ([25:1-40:38](#)) is that God intends to meet his people’s need for some tangible representation of his presence, but it must be done in the way he has commanded. He, not we, determines the terms by which we come to him.

Exodus 31:12-18

The Sabbath was understood to be the unique sign of the covenant ([31:13](#), [16](#), [17](#); see also [20:8-11](#); [Isa 58:13-14](#); [Jer 17:21-27](#); [Neh 13:15-22](#)). The Sabbath is also said to figure significantly in the achievement of God’s underlying purpose of making his people holy, that is, set apart for his exclusive use and sharing his character ([Exod 31:13](#), [14](#), [15](#)). Resting from their own work ([31:15](#), [17](#)) was also a practical way of demonstrating genuine dependence on God to meet their needs (see [20:8-11](#) and study notes).

Exodus 31:14-15

It is absolutely important to learn that we can find life in God only by coming to him in his way. This is underlined by the death sentence for disobedience (see also [Num 15:32-36](#)). This is not to say that followers of God must always punish those who

commit these offenses in this way; but here at the outset, it was vital to make this truth clear (see [Acts 5:1-11](#)). If the spiritual truth of this lesson has not been learned, mere ritual obedience will be of no value (see [Col 2:16-19](#)).

Exodus 31:18

Normally, each party to a covenant received a written copy of the terms of the covenant. So it may be that the two stone tablets were identical, one being God’s copy and the other the people’s copy, to be kept together in the Ark of the Covenant. • finger of God: See [34:28](#).

Exodus 32:1

The Israelites’ actions were motivated by fear, disrespect for this fellow Moses, disbelief in God’s leadership, and denial of responsibility. They were unwilling to wait for God to reveal his plans of care for them. Refusal to wait on God is often a cause of sin (see [1 Sam 13:7-13](#); [Isa 30:15-18](#)).

Exodus 32:1-6

The people were not willing to wait and see what God had been saying to Moses on the mountain for the forty days while he was there (see [24:18](#)).

Exodus 32:1-35

At the foot of Mount Sinai, after Moses had been absent for many days, the people felt the need for protection, guidance, and a tangible way to express their worship. God knew this and was eager to meet these needs (chs [25-31](#)). The Israelites, however, tried to meet their needs for themselves. Fellowship with God requires depending on him (see [John 15:5](#); [2 Cor 3:5](#)).

Exodus 32:2-4

The religious professional, Aaron, demanded a specific contribution of gold rings and then excluded the people from any further involvement in the process. This is very different from what God had commanded regarding the construction of the Tabernacle, where the people were invited to bring

many different kinds of things as they felt led ([25:1-9](#); [35:4-36:7](#)) and to share in the work under the guidance of a Spirit-filled layperson ([31:1-6](#); [36:1-2](#)).

Exodus 32:4

the shape of a calf: The idol might actually have been an image of a bull, like the images of the Egyptian god Amon-Re that the people had known in Egypt. The bull represented power, domination, and fertility. The writer would then be using the term calf as a way of expressing contempt for the idol. Alternatively, Aaron might have made a calf, feeling that this sin was not as serious as if the idol were a full-sized bull. • these are the gods who brought you out: The people attributed to the idol what they had just said that Moses had done ([32:1](#)). Idolatry expresses the belief that the divine realm and the visible world are continuous with one another. This worldview sees it as possible to lay hold of divine power through ritual manipulation of the god by means of the idol. God had been insisting that the very opposite is true: God is *not* contained in or restrained by his creation, and his blessings cannot be procured by manipulating creation, either ritually or otherwise. The blessings of God are for those who surrender their own efforts to make themselves secure and come to him using the ways and means that he has decreed.

Exodus 32:5

Aaron attempted to control the process, but he was actually abdicating leadership by simply doing what he thought the people wanted. • Although the idol was referred to as “the gods” ([32:4](#)), Aaron also implied that it was a physical manifestation of the Lord.

Exodus 32:6

The Hebrew term translated pagan revelry is traditionally rendered *they got up to play*. As in English, the Hebrew word for *play* can have sexual overtones (see [Gen 26:8](#), “caressing”), which is likely the case here. Worship of a fertility symbol such as a bull was often accompanied by sexual activities on the part of the worshipers (see [1 Cor 10:7-8](#)).

Exodus 32:7

Your people whom you brought from the land of Egypt: God here attributes his own work to Moses, which suggests that he was testing Moses, giving him an opportunity to make the same mistake the people had made ([32:1](#)). God was not “tempting” Moses in the sense of “seducing him to do evil” (see [Jas 1:13-14](#)), but he was putting Moses into a situation where he was faced with a clear choice that could take him in opposing directions (cp. [1 Kgs 22:19-23](#)).

Exodus 32:9-10

God was apparently prepared to disown his people, since they had broken their covenant with him.

Exodus 32:10

Now leave me alone: This apparent command was in fact an invitation to Moses to intercede for his people. Although the people deserved destruction, God was willing not to destroy them if Moses continued to stand before him as an intercessor. • I will make you, Moses, into a great nation: If Moses were willing, God would start over again, abandoning the rest of the children of Abraham and beginning now with the children of Moses. This was apparently a test of Moses’ understanding of God.

Exodus 32:11-13

If a test was involved, Moses passed it. He refused to put himself in God’s place ([32:11](#)). He knew that God is just and faithful and that he would not deliver people only to destroy them ([32:12](#)). He refused to accept the invitation to become the father of a great nation, since that would involve God’s breaking his promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob ([32:13](#)). Moses had learned who God really is.

Exodus 32:14

In response to Moses’ argument, the Lord changed his mind. This is not the picture of a raging tyrant who is, with great difficulty, finally persuaded to back down. The Lord is much more inclined to be merciful than to insist on vengeance, and he invites those who are near him, like Moses, to give him an

occasion for his mercy through faithful intercession.

Exodus 32:15-29

When Moses actually saw what was going on, he was much less calm than he had been on the mountain. He smashed the tablets ([32:15-19](#)), destroyed the calf ([32:20](#)), confronted Aaron ([32:21-25](#)), and had the ringleaders killed ([32:26-29](#)).

Exodus 32:16

The tablets were the work of God: The covenant was more than just a human agreement.

Exodus 32:19

While the act of smashing the tablets might simply have been a reaction of fury, it might also have been Moses' way of saying that the covenant with God was now irrevocably broken. God later reminded Moses rather pointedly that Moses was the one who had smashed the tablets (see [34:1](#)).

Exodus 32:20

Passing the gold powder of the image through the bodies of the people effectively rendered it unclean.

Exodus 32:21-25

Aaron denied responsibility even though he himself had made the molds and poured the gold ([32:4](#)). Aaron wanted Moses to believe that it all "just happened" ([32:24](#)) and that he had no choice because the people were so evil ([32:22](#)). Moses was not misled. He knew that Aaron could have led the people but had let them get completely out of control ([32:25](#)).

Exodus 32:25

much to the amusement of their enemies: After the Israelites' great show of worshiping the Lord as a

different kind of God, their actions proclaimed that he was merely another of the idols that their enemies had been worshiping all along (see [Ezek 36:19-20](#)).

Exodus 32:26-29

Moses had asked God to spare the people, but now he called on those who followed the Lord to kill those who had sinned. The Levites ([32:26](#)) were willing to confront the sin that Aaron had let loose. Although Moses commanded them to kill everyone ([32:27](#)), the number 3,000 ([32:28](#)) makes it clear that the word *everyone* had a restricted meaning. The reference to your own sons and brothers suggests that as Aaron had led in the idolatry, many of the Levites had led in the worship of the idol, and they were the ones that the rest of the Levites killed. Aaron may have escaped because God had already designated him as high priest ([28:1](#)).

Exodus 32:30-35

This further intercession for the people may have been needed because of Moses' new recognition of how serious the sin really was.

Exodus 32:32

As if underlining his earlier refusal of God's invitation to become a great nation at the people's expense, Moses here rather piously asked God to destroy him, too, if he chose not to forgive the people.

Exodus 32:33

God dismissed Moses' request. He would bring judgment only on those who had sinned in the incident.

Exodus 32:34

the place I told you about: Canaan, which God had promised to give to Abraham's descendants (see [3:17](#); [32:13](#); [33:1](#)). • when I come to call the people to account: Because of God's mercy, judgment may not always come immediately (though in this instance God soon sent a plague, [32:35](#)), but it will

come for those who persist in sin (see [Matt 13:24–30](#)).

Exodus 33:1–6

God would not lead the people up to Canaan as he had previously led them (see [33:3](#); but see also [33:14–17](#)). Instead, he would send an angel ([33:2](#)).

Exodus 33:2–3

an angel. . . . But I will not travel: This angel was possibly not the “angel of the Lord,” since in Exodus and other parts of the Old Testament, the angel of the Lord is closely associated with the presence of the Lord himself (see [3:2](#); [23:20–23](#)). Or, God might have been saying that while he would go before them in the person of the angel ([33:2](#)), he would not dwell among them ([33:3](#)) in the Tabernacle, as he had planned. • Canaanites . . . Jebusites: See study note on 3:8.

Exodus 33:3

land that flows with milk and honey: Although Canaan was not as fertile as the Nile Valley in Egypt, it was a great deal more productive agriculturally than the Sinai Desert where they were. • stubborn and rebellious: They were covenant-breakers. • I would surely destroy you: As the Covenant Lord (see study note on 23:20–33), he would enforce the terms of the covenant that called for the destruction of covenant-breakers (see [24:7–8](#) and study notes).

Exodus 33:4–6

The jewelry and fine clothes might have been worn while worshiping the gold calf. Here their removal signifies mourning ([33:4](#)) and repentance.

Exodus 33:7

The tabernacle is often called the *Tent of Meeting* (see study note on 27:21). In many passages, these two expressions refer to the same structure.

However, in this passage, the *Tent of Meeting* refers to a different, temporary tent. Moses set up this

tent outside the camp before the tabernacle was built.

Later, when the tabernacle was completed, it was placed in the center of the camp (see [Numbers 2:1–31](#)).

Exodus 33:7–11

The way God communicated with his people before the completion of the tabernacle is likely described here. This helps explain the events recorded in [33:1–6](#) and [33:12–23](#).

Exodus 33:8–11

would stand ... stand up and bow down: The people considered it amazing that Moses spoke directly to God, “face to face” ([33:11](#)).

Exodus 33:11

Joshua had earlier gained experience as a military leader (see [17:9–13](#)). Now, he was gaining experience as a spiritual leader (see also [24:13](#)). He may have stayed behind to guard the tent, a function the Levites would later fulfill with the tabernacle ([1 Chronicles 26](#)).

Exodus 33:12

I know you by name: God chose Moses himself.

Exodus 33:12–23

Moses begged for God to go with him and the people to the Promised Land. In these verses the word personally ([33:14–15](#)) usually reflects a Hebrew term literally rendered *face*. Moses wanted to continue experiencing the “face to face” relationship he had begun to have ([33:11](#)). He also wanted the people to have that experience in some sense.

Exodus 33:13

let me know your ways: Moses did not merely want God’s blessings; he wanted to know God’s nature

and character, as well as the manner of and reasons for his actions. God's goal of revealing himself was beginning to be realized, at least in one person. • Moses wanted God himself to accompany them, because they were the Lord's own people.

Exodus 33:14

I will give you rest: Literally *a place to roost*, as in a place where a bird can land and be at peace. Ever since Abraham left Ur, he and his descendants had had no such place.

Exodus 33:15-16

Moses made his request even more direct. Again he showed his understanding of what God was doing. The Exodus was not merely about getting the Israelites out of Egypt so they could go to Canaan. It was about a personal experience of God that would change how they lived. If that was not possible, then they might just as well have stayed at Sinai. Going on to Canaan would be disastrous without the Lord.

Exodus 33:17

The Lord reaffirmed his agreement to go with them and his personal appointment of Moses.

Exodus 33:18

Moses asked for confirmation of God's promises. He asked to see God's glorious presence (literally *glory*). He was asking for an experience of seeing the very essence of God (see study note on 16:7).

Exodus 33:19

In his positive reply, God subtly changed the terms. He would grant Moses a glorious experience, but he would not show Moses his face. Rather, he would show him his goodness and express his character (my name), marked above all by mercy and compassion (see [Rom 9:14-16](#)). • Yahweh: Here God is emphasizing his own personal name.

Exodus 33:20-23

God longs to show us his character, but to see his face (his essence) and his glorious presence ([33:22](#)) would be to die. Moses was permitted a glimpse of that, but nothing more.

Exodus 34:1-3

God called Moses to come back up Mount Sinai with two new stone tablets. The restrictions for the rest of the people are like those made at first (see [19:12-13](#), [21-25](#)).

Exodus 34:1-35

God granted Moses' request ([33:18](#)), showed Moses his goodness ([34:1-9](#)), and renewed the covenant ([34:10-35](#)). This renewal was a unilateral statement by God. God would indeed go with his people, maintaining his covenant promises even though they had broken the covenant ([32:1-6](#)) and deserved nothing better than death and abandonment.

Exodus 34:5-6

the LORD: This represents the personal name of God, *Yahweh*. This name appears five times in this passage. By repeating this name, God emphasizes his personal name. This shows that he is speaking and acting as the covenant God (the God who makes promises) of his people.

Exodus 34:5-9

Moses experienced God's presence in a revelation of the name, or character, of God. As God had promised ([33:19](#)), he showed Moses the glory of his goodness.

Exodus 34:6

compassion and mercy (see [20:5-6](#); [33:19](#) and study notes): The Creator who was revealing himself to the Israelites, and through them to the world, is a God of grace. Neither his justice nor his sovereignty are underlined here, as true as those attributes are. If God were merely just, the Old

Testament would have ended at this point, or it would have picked up and started again with an entirely new family. This did not happen because God, in his unique character, is slow to anger and full of unfailing love and faithfulness. These qualities were the basis for his renewal of the covenant.

Exodus 34:7

God's unfailing love and his generous desire to forgive are not weakness or indecisiveness, nor are they reason to sin. Sin will have its effects, because God created a world of cause and effect. The murderer may repent, be forgiven, and lead a new life, but the effects of previous choices will continue to play out. We should not sin just because we know that God will forgive (see study note on 20:5–6). • a thousand generations: See [Deut 7:9–11](#). • I lay the sins of the parents: Our sins affect future generations of descendants, but God restricts the natural effect of those sins to three or four generations. See also [Exod 20:5–6](#).

Exodus 34:8–9

Since the Lord had already twice promised to go with them ([33:14, 17](#)), this renewed request seems to show a lack of faith. It may also be that God's presence had driven home to Moses how absolutely holy God is and how very different he is from this stubborn and rebellious people. Here Moses took his request a step further and asked God to travel with the people and make them his own special possession (see [19:5–6](#)). Moses asked for the complete restoration of the relationship.

Exodus 34:10–11

God promised to miraculously care for his people as he brought them into Canaan. This care depended on their obedience. In Hebrew, the word translated as *observe* also means "obey" ([34:11](#)). Unlike English, Hebrew does not separate hearing a command from obeying it.

Exodus 34:10–26

Some of the terms of the covenant are restated, particularly those that prohibit the worship of

other gods and that describe the proper worship of the Lord.

Exodus 34:12–17

Worship of idols was prohibited, particularly the idols of the peoples into whose lands the Israelites were going. Central to this restriction was the prohibition of treaties, or covenants, with these idol-worshipping peoples. Not only would the making of a treaty involve recognizing those peoples' gods (because ancient treaties would call upon the gods as witnesses; see study note on 20:1–23:33), but the very existence of the treaties would predispose the Israelites to accept the ways of their treaty partners ([34:12, 15–16](#)).

Exodus 34:13

Asherah was a Canaanite fertility goddess who would continue to be a temptation throughout Israel's history (see, e.g., [Judg 6:25](#); [1 Kgs 14:15](#); [2 Kgs 23:15](#)). • The poles seem to have been fertility symbols.

Exodus 34:16

Intermarriage with pagans was a problem throughout the Old Testament (see [Gen 24:3](#); [Ezra 9:1–2](#); cp. [2 Cor 6:14–18](#)).

Exodus 34:22

Feast of Ingathering: See study notes on 23:16; Leviticus 23:15–21, 34–43.

Exodus 34:23

three times: See [23:14–17](#).

Exodus 34:24

no one will covet your land: If Israel would trust God and obey him, he would protect them.

Exodus 34:27-28

Moses wrote down this reiteration of the general terms of the covenant ([34:27](#)). The Ten Commandments, the summary of the terms, were written on the new tablets ([34:28](#)).

Exodus 34:29-35

Moses, who had asked to see the glory of God, wasn't aware that his own face reflected that glory.

Exodus 34:33

covered his face with a veil: While Moses was reporting what God had said to him, he left his face unveiled. Then he covered it, perhaps because of the fright ([34:30](#)) its radiance caused during ordinary discourse (see [2 Cor 3:7-18](#) for Paul's reflection on this incident).

Exodus 35:1-40:38

Much of the report of the building of the Tabernacle reiterates what was said in [25:1-31:18](#). There is a change from the imperative mood to the indicative, and there are certain changes in the order. This repetition underlines the point that the work was done exactly as God had commanded (see [40:16](#)). The people had tried to secure God's presence in their own way with the gold calf, and the result was disaster. Now they were doing it in God's way, resulting in blessing ([40:34-38](#)).

Exodus 35:4-36:7

Unlike the creation of the gold calf, where Aaron demanded that one type of material (earrings) be given (see study note on [32:2-4](#)), the people were again invited to bring a variety of gifts ([35:4-9](#)) as their hearts were stirred and their spirits were moved ([35:21](#)). Perhaps because the variety of gifts meant that everyone could bring something and because the giving was voluntary, the people gave too much and had to be commanded to stop ([36:4-7](#)).

Exodus 37:1-29

While it is said that Bezalel made the Ark and all the rest of the furnishings ([37:1](#), [10](#), [17](#), [25](#)) as well as the courtyard and its furnishings ([38:1](#), [8](#), [9](#), [18](#)), this is probably only a way of saying that he was responsible and directed the other craftsmen and seamstresses.

Exodus 38:1-20

This section reports on building the courtyard ([38:9-20](#)) and its equipment, including the altar of burnt offering ([38:1-7](#)) and the washbasin ([38:8](#)).

Exodus 38:8

While the plans for the washbasin ([30:17-21](#)) were included in the instructions to the priests ([29:38-30:38](#)), here its construction is reported in logical sequence. • This bronze, which could be polished to a mirror-like finish, was probably of especially high quality, as was fitting for use in God's Tabernacle.

Exodus 38:21

Since the Tabernacle contained the Ark of the Covenant, it is called the Tabernacle of the Covenant.

Exodus 38:21-29

The immense amount of metal reported in this inventory of materials (more than a ton of gold, almost four tons of silver, and two and a half tons of bronze) reflects the Egyptians' eagerness to get the Israelites out of Egypt, giving the Israelites anything they asked for in order to hurry them on their way (see [12:35-36](#)).

Exodus 38:26

For the earlier discussion of this tax, see [30:11-16](#). The sanctuary shekel was evidently the standard against which other weights were measured for accuracy. • 603,550: See study note on [12:37](#).

Exodus 39:1–31

See [Exodus 28:1–43](#).

Exodus 39:30

The term *holy crown* might be a formal title. The initial description of the plate in [28:36](#) does not include that term.

Exodus 39:32–43

Moses inspected the finished work and confirmed that everything had been done just as the Lord had commanded ([39:43](#)). As a result, Moses blessed them instead of pronouncing judgment upon them, as when they had tried to meet their need for God's presence in their own ways ([32:27](#)).

Exodus 40:1–33

The report on setting up the Tabernacle begins with the Lord's commands to do so ([40:1–15](#)) and continues with the report on how Moses obeyed those commands ([40:16–33](#)). • The repeated statement that Moses did everything just as the Lord had commanded him ([40:16](#), [19](#), [21](#), [23](#), [25](#), [27](#), [29](#), [32](#)) is in radical contrast to Aaron's self-serving statement in [32:22–24](#). God wishes to share his presence with us, but his holiness is such that this can occur only if we renounce our own efforts to secure his presence and gifts.

Exodus 40:2

In the Tabernacle, the divine King met with Israel to communicate his will to them. • the first day of the new year: The Tabernacle was set up one year after God announced the Passover and the start of Israel's calendar.

Exodus 40:3

The Hebrew word translated Covenant is 'eduth ("testimony"), which refers particularly to the covenant stipulations. The written copy of these stipulations contained in the Ark would serve as a testimony to the covenant Israel had entered into with God.

Exodus 40:33

So Moses finished the work: This statement marks the completion of the work on the tabernacle. The long process of building and preparing all its parts had now come to an end. See study note on [37:1–29](#).

Exodus 40:34–38

The climax of the Exodus occurred when the glory of the Lord filled the Tabernacle. God's goal from the outset was not merely to deliver his people from their bondage, but to bring them into a relationship with himself. Their real need was to know God personally in their lives. Without that, the Promised Land would not be a land of promise. Now it would be, because the glory that had been on Mount Sinai was in Israel's midst; it would not be left behind but would travel with them wherever they might go.

Exodus 40:38

the whole family of Israel: This description is reminiscent of the way the book began (see [1:1–7](#)). Jacob's family had become slaves in Egypt. What a dramatic change had occurred! They were no longer slaves. They were now in a position to be a blessing to the earth, as God had promised to Abraham generations earlier ([Gen 12:3](#)).